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UCC to permanently polarise society: Congress

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Mirabai Chanu ends 12-year Asian Games medal wait with silver

Election panel denies internal rift

As questions mount over voter rolls and SIR, ECI says internal objections are part of deliberations

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday denied fissures within the poll body after a report in a national daily said that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had questioned multiple issues, including deletion of names in various States as part of the pan-India Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voters' list, integrity of voter software and changes in work allocation, triggering a massive political storm.

The ECI, in a press note published on social media on Wednesday, said "differing views" and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution and all its orders carry full legal sanction and follow established statutory procedures.

"Differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution. They are a part of the decision-making process before a final decision is taken. Not only the three

BJP defends Gyanesh Kumar as Opposition closes ranks on CEC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Red flags allegedly raised by two Election Commissioners within the poll panel over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voter list triggered a political storm on Wednesday, with the Opposition demanding Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar's removal and the ruling BJP asserting that differing views are a normal part of deliberation.

ECI selection law to face larger SC Bench

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma gave split opinions on the pleas challenging the validity of the law on appointment of election commissioners

LG orders audit of parks in Capital

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Two days after a minor was sexually assaulted by three men in a park near Kalkaji Mandir, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu called for a safety review of all public parks in the city, to be finished within a week.

Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar asked all 15 district DCPs to find dark spots, broken cameras, and other safety issues in parks, roads and isolated areas. The police is to send these lists to the civic authorities responsible for the infrastructure. Aastha

Jaishankar, Rubio meet over Russia oil sanctions

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India's concerns over Washington's latest sanctions framework targeting countries that continue to purchase Russian energy emerged as a key issue during External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's meeting with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly on Wednesday.

Global ratings agencies raise India growth projection to 7%

RAHUL DATTA
■ New Delhi

Global ratings agencies S&P, Fitch, Asian Development Bank (ADB) and Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) on Wednesday raised India's FY27 GDP growth projection to around 7 per cent, boosted by robust June quarter economic activity and resilient domestic demand despite conflict in West Asia.

Additionally, S&P and Fitch said inflationary pressures will push the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to hike policy interest rates by at least 25 basis points this year while raising India's GDP growth forecast for this year to 7 per cent, from 6.6 per cent previously. Paris-based OECD raised GDP growth forecast for India by 80 basis points to 7.1 per cent — the highest growth rate so far projected by any international agency for FY27.

ADB, while raising the growth forecast to 7 per cent, from 6.6 per cent estimated in July, said the Indian economy has benefited from lower-than-expected supply disruptions and sustained capital inflows, which helped cushion the impact of the conflict in West Asia. While Fitch Ratings said

INDIAN SEAFARER KILLED OFF OMAN

India has strongly condemned an attack on the commercial vessel MV Cape Dao off the east coast of Oman, which resulted in the tragic death of an Indian seafarer. The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) confirmed that out of 20 Indian crew members on board, 19 have been safely rescued. The Indian Embassy in Muscat is closely coordinating with Omani authorities to ensure the early repatriation of the surviving crew and the return of the deceased's mortal remains. Calling the continuing incidents of maritime violence "deeply worrisome," New Delhi reiterated that the targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers, and civilian infrastructure must end immediately. The MEA emphasized restoring free and unimpeded navigation through international waterways and called for dialogue and diplomacy to de-escalate regional tensions.

MP TRADERS OBSERVE NO UPI DAY

Traders across several Madhya Pradesh cities observed a No UPI Day on Wednesday, covering their store QR codes with black cloth to protest the Centre's decision to levy a 0.4 per cent Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI transactions exceeding ₹2,000, effective October 15. Organised by trade federations, the protest spanned Indore, Bhopal, Jabalpur, and Gwalior. Protesters urged customers to shift to cash payments, arguing that the extra cost will ultimately burden the common public. Trade leaders warned that code machines would be submerged in water bodies if the fee is not rolled back. Meanwhile, the Government maintains that customers will not incur any additional charges.

THE BYSTANDER

Take rest. I am in action...

MP TRADERS OBSERVE NO UPI DAY

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CM flags off special metro train to promote Govt schemes

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National Capital’s park safety reset after Aastha Kunj gang rape

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Two days after a 17-year-old girl from Faridabad was allegedly assaulted in Aastha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir, Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu ordered a safety audit of all public parks to be finished within a week, with emphasis on adequate lighting, security, regular patrolling and cleanliness.

Following the LG’s order, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) issued safety measures for all its parks.

The security measures include increased vigilance by security personnel during evening hours, restricted access after sunset, installation of CCTV cameras at entry gates, and other steps.

Earlier in the morning, Sandhu met the Delhi Police Commissioner, MCD Commissioner and DDA Vice Chairman at the Lok Niwas and directed a comprehensive safety audit of all parks within one week.

Delhi Police Commissioner

Anurag Kumar also asked all 15 district DCPs to find dark areas, broken cameras, and other safety issues in parks, roads, and isolated spots, and to send these lists to the agencies that can fix them.

The 17-year-old girl from Faridabad was gang-raped by three men at Ashta Kunj Park near the Kalkaji temple on Monday evening.

All three accused were arrested. One accused, Asif, was arrested after an encounter with the police, in which he sustained a bullet injury to the leg, police said.

However, the larger problem is bigger than this single incident. Aastha Kunj is not just a small neighbourhood park. It is a DDA park that covers about 142 acres, with around 29 entry points connecting the Kalkaji temple complex, the Lotus Temple side, and ISKCON.

Some sections of the park’s outer boundary have also collapsed. Several gates do not have guards. Guard cabins near important entrances lack electricity.



CCTV cameras at entry and exit points are either missing or not working. The lighting on the path used that night was insufficient.

The DDA says it has checked the lighting, placed nine guards per shift at key spots, and is reviewing staffing again. The DDA Vice Chairman has also issued comprehensive directions to strengthen safety and security arrangements across all

DDA parks for the interim period ahead of the audit, with the authority saying it has taken immediate cognisance of the incident and initiated a series of preventive and citizen-centric measures.

Under these directions, parks with multiple entry gates will adopt controlled entry arrangements after sunset, restricting access through selected gates before closing time.

At the same time, visitors will be advised to use well-lit pathways and illuminated areas in the evening.

CCTV cameras are also being installed or augmented at main entry gates and other vulnerable locations to improve monitoring and enable prompt response. But with 29 entrances and thick vegetation, that many guards are not enough. The audit will need to look at this problem.

Police Commissioner’s order treats the park as an example to study, not as a special case.

Officers have been asked to report broken streetlights, non-functioning cameras, unmanned areas, and isolated spots wherever they find them, whether in parks, bus stands, or on roads.

They should also inform the agency responsible for repairs. The process allows police to patrol and report issues. Only the MCD or DDA can fix the lights or cameras.

Sandhu’s meeting at Lok Niwas brought together Delhi Police, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, and the Delhi Development Authority. The audit will focus on lighting, security presence, regular patrols, and cleanliness, with a strict one-week deadline.

Police have also been told to increase patrols along park edges and deploy Pink Police units along the boundaries.

Beat constables and local officers have been told to visit parks regularly, not only after an incident.

The DDA and MCD have been asked to consider working with resident welfare groups, private companies, and schools on park maintenance.

Attendance, patrolling, and performance of deployed security guards are also to be monitored more rigorously through field inspections, with Resident Welfare Associations and local stakeholders to be actively involved in strengthening vigilance and promoting community-based safety.

Within seven days, public safety information boards displaying park rules, emergency contacts and safety guidelines are also to be installed across all DDA parks, while any suspicious or illegal activities around parks are to be promptly reported to police authorities for immediate action.

This shows that the current system of guards and lights is not enough for all the city’s parks. The Pink Police plan comes from an earlier order to create a visible women’s

police unit, similar to Goa’s Pink Force, to patrol schools, colleges, metro stations, and other high-risk places and times.

Police officers say the week-long audit should reveal the real problems. Delhi’s parks are run by either the DDA or MCD, vary in size, and often have official closing times that do not match what actually happens at the gates.

Aastha Kunj is open from early morning until 9 pm, and the incident occurred within that time. If the audit merely looks at the poles and the cameras, it will fail to address some important issues: the number of gates that are open, who is on duty after dark, whether the broken walls allow people to get in, and whether nine guards are actually capable of keeping watch over a 142-acre park full of trees and stone structures.

DDA manages over 16,000 acres of green assets, including 675 parks, biodiversity zones, city forests, regional parks and neighbourhood gardens.

LSR students hold *Azaadi* march over safety after minor’s assault near campus

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chants of “*Azaadi*” filled the air as students of Lady Shri Ram College for Women (LSR) took out a solidarity march on Wednesday, raising concerns over women’s safety following the alleged gang rape of a 17-year-old girl near Aastha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir.

The college will resume offline classes and its regular academic schedule from Thursday, a day after it shifted classes online following the alleged rape of a 17-year-old girl at nearby Aastha Kunj Park on Wednesday.

The protesting students, gathered amid heightened security outside the campus, held talks with Delhi Police officials through the day, pressing for answers on safety around the college, the adjoining lanes and the park where the assault took place.

The all-women march saw students raising slogans and carrying posters highlighting the need for better security infrastructure around the college and its adjoining areas, as yet another alleged rape incident brought the longstanding demand for women’s safety into focus.

“Moral policing women will not stop rape” and “A woman’s body isn’t a battleground for your power” were among the posters displayed



Lady Shri Ram College (LSR) students hold a solidarity march demanding enhanced safety measures following the alleged gang rape of a 17-year-old girl at nearby Aastha Kunj Park in New Delhi on Wednesday

during the protest.

Most participants had their faces covered, but it did not diminish the anger expressed through slogans like “*Meri mukti, teri mukti, nari mukti, zindabad*” and “*Azaadi*”.

The students marched towards Moolchand metro station before returning to the college.

The protesters raised concerns about inadequate lighting, a lack of regular patrolling, insufficient CCTV surveillance, and a dysfunctional pink booth in the area. Another poster circulated ahead of the march said, “It’s not my fault I crave the night air, it’s your fault you crave taking it away from me”, and mentioned that the march would be open to “all women

and queerfolk”.

Students alleged that incidents of stalking and harassment near the college’s back gate had been reported to the administration repeatedly, but security concerns remained unaddressed. The march was organised to express solidarity with the survivor and demand stronger measures to ensure women’s safety in and around the college.

The college had suspended physical classes from noon on Tuesday and shifted teaching online after the encounter, which took place near DM Office Road in Amar Colony. “Meetings are going on offline with a large number of students and faculty. Offline classes and

regular schedule shall resume from tomorrow,” LSR principal Kanika K Ahuja said.

Anusha Garg, president of the LSR Students’ Union, said around 2,000 to 3,000 women students live in paying guest accommodation and other housing in the vicinity of Aastha Kunj Park and attend the college, underlining how closely student life in the area is tied to the same lanes and park now under scrutiny.

The college administration has since sought enhanced security arrangements from Delhi Police in and around the campus, specifically asking Amar Colony police station to increase patrolling in the lanes adjoining the college, particularly around

SENIOR POLICE OFFICIALS MEET LSR PRINCIPAL, ASSURE ENHANCED SECURITY

New Delhi: Senior Delhi Police officers, including Joint Commissioner of Police (Southern Range) Vijay Kumar, visited the Lady Shri Ram College for Women on Wednesday and held a meeting with the principal following the alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old girl at nearby Aastha Kunj Park, officials said.

The visit came a day after the college cancelled regular classes and shifted those online for Wednesday following concerns raised by students over their safety in and around the area. The college, located around two km from the park where the alleged incident took place, will resume regular offline classes from Thursday.

During the meeting, police assured the college administration that their presence in and around the campus would be increased and that immediate response would be provided in case of any emergency, the officials said. Police will also write to the civic and other authorities concerned regarding improving infrastructure, including lighting at dark spots in the area, they said.

As part of the security arrangements, Delhi Police personnel have been deployed outside the college campus, while women police personnel and women PCR vans have also been stationed in the area, the officials said.

A pink booth – a women-focused police assistance kiosk – has also been made functional in the area since September 17, they added.

The senior police officers held discussions with the college administration regarding the security of students and reviewed arrangements around the campus. “We will ensure that women feel safe and that law and order is maintained,” one of the officers said.

Police detain 379 in park crackdown



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two days after the alleged gangrape of a 17-year-old girl at Aastha Kunj Park here, the Delhi Police has intensified area-domination and patrolling operations across vulnerable public spaces, with officers focusing on parks, dark spots, subways, foot-over bridges and other locations where women may feel unsafe.

The Central Range of Delhi Police conducted coordinated Combing and Search Operations (CASO) across identified public spaces on Tuesday and Wednesday and apprehended 379 people under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act, in addition to action taken under the Delhi Excise Act, COTPA, the Gambling Act, the BNSS, and the POCSO Act, officials said.

The operations aim to increase police visibility, prevent unlawful activities, and reclaim public spaces vulnerable to encroachment by miscreants or habitual offenders, they said.

The move comes following the alleged gangrape at Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir on Monday evening. Officials said three men allegedly posed as policemen and raped a teenage girl, threatening her and her male friend. The incident also brought renewed attention to security arrangements, lighting and police presence in and around public parks and other secluded areas.

In Darya Ganj, police checked five parks and apprehended 66 people under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act. In the Jama Masjid area, police checked several parks and public spaces, taking action against 45 people under the same provision, as well as taking preventive action under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

In the Kamla Market area,

police checked multiple parks, including Minto Road Complex Park, Shivaji Park, DBG Park, Nehru Park and Shastri Park. Police detained 60 people under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act, seized three vehicles, and took action under the Delhi Excise Act and the BNSS.

In Patel Nagar, police checked five parks and apprehended 82 people under Section 65 of the Delhi Police Act, along with preventive action under the Excise Act and the BNSS. At Prasad Nagar, police proceeded with action against 23 people under Section 40(A) of the Delhi Excise Act, along with additional action under the Gambling Act and the Excise Act. Officials said they also checked 33 bad characters during the coordinated operations.

Police teams simultaneously conducted security audits of public spaces to identify infrastructure-related vulnerabilities, including inadequate lighting and dark spots, broken fencing, encroachments, vulnerable entry and exit points, and poorly secured subways and foot-over bridges.

Officials said police will inform the Public Works Department, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, and other civic agencies to take remedial action if they notice any drawback. Police said the exercise follows the broader “broken windows” approach, under which visible signs of disorder and neglect in public spaces are addressed alongside conventional policing to deter unlawful activity and improve public confidence.

Officials said 18 additional women constables have been posted to the Women Police Station in North District, while women-led “Jhansi” patrolling squads on pink scooters conducted intensive patrols in vulnerable areas.

LG clears 5.5-km elevated road, Mukarba Chowk revamp and last-mile plans for 31 metro stations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi commuters are set to get a 5.5-km elevated corridor in South Delhi, a widened flyover at the perennially jammed Mukarba Chowk, and improved walking access to 31 Metro stations across the city, after Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu chaired the 70th Governing Body Meeting of the Unified Traffic & Transportation Infrastructure (Planning & Engineering) Centre (UTTIPEC) on Wednesday and cleared eight major connectivity projects in one sitting.

The meeting approved six Multi Modal Integration (MMI) plans prepared by DMRC and two road projects by PWD, GNCTD, all aimed at easing last-mile travel, improving

pedestrian infrastructure and reducing traffic congestion at key points across the capital.

For daily commuters, the biggest relief may come from the proposed six-lane elevated corridor on Maa Anandmayee Marg, running approximately 5.5 km from Outer Ring Road to Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, along with an underpass and roundabout at the Crowne Plaza intersection on Okhla Estate Marg.

The corridor will bypass about 12 intersections that currently cause bottlenecks, easing congestion from traffic in the Okhla Phase I and II industrial areas. With reduced vehicle movement at ground level, the project will also open up space for better pedestrian and non-motorised transport infrastructure along the stretch.



At Mukarba Chowk in North West Delhi, one of the city’s most congested traffic points, the approved project involves widening the existing Road Over Bridge on Outer Ring Road from six lanes to 10, along with a new four-lane ROB connect-

ing Jahangirpuri Industrial Area with Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar over the Delhi-Sonipat rail line. Officials expect the new connecting road to divert nearly 20 per cent of vehicular traffic currently passing through Mukarba Chowk, easing pres-

sure on both the chowk itself and NH-44 in the vicinity, a stretch that has long been a daily headache for commuters travelling between Mukarba Chowk and Madhuban Chowk.

On the public transport side, the meeting approved MMI plans for six more Metro stations: GTB Nagar on the Yellow Line, Sarita Vihar on the Violet Line, Akshardham on the Blue Line, Rohini West/Dr Baba Saheb Ambedkar Hospital on the Red Line, Malviya Nagar on the Yellow Line, and Shastri Park on the Red Line. With this approval, UTTIPEC has cleared all 31 MMI plans prepared by DMRC for Metro stations across Phase I and II corridors in Delhi.

These plans, covering roughly 300 metres around each station, are designed to improve how people actual-

ly reach and move around Metro and RTTS stations, focusing on walkability, pedestrian safety and last-mile connectivity- the everyday gap between stepping off a train and reaching one’s final destination that commuters across Delhi regularly navigate on foot, cycle or rickshaw.

Senior representatives from DDA, GNCTD, the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Delhi Traffic Police, DMRC, PWD, MCD, NDMC, Indian Railways, NCRTC and other concerned agencies attended the meeting.

Taken together, officials said the approved projects would improve Metro station connectivity, make last-mile access more convenient and safer for pedestrians, and ease congestion at some of Delhi’s most persistent traffic chokepoints.

Cabinet clears 1,300 pink e-autos; women with over three kids ineligible

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Women aged 20-40 with more than three children or whose family owns a transport vehicle or three-wheeler will not be eligible for the Delhi Government’s DURGA scheme, under which 1,300 pink electric autos will be allocated in the first phase. The scheme, approved by the Delhi Cabinet on Wednesday, provides for 1,170 electric autos for women and 130 for transgender beneficiaries, with applications to be invited through a dedicated online portal.

DURGA stands for Upliftment and Rozgar for Women/

Transgender Green E-Auto. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta chaired the Cabinet meeting where the scheme was approved, aimed at providing dignified self-employment opportunities while promoting women’s safety, greater transgender participation in the transport sector, last-mile connectivity and clean, sustainable urban transport.

The Chief Minister said economically empowering women and transgender persons while connecting them with safe transport remains among the Delhi Government’s priorities, describing DURGA as an important step in this direction. She said the scheme would let women and transgender

persons own and drive electric autos, providing dignified self-employment opportunities while making Delhi’s public transport more accessible and inclusive.

The Chief Minister said women and transgender passengers face commuting and safety challenges, particularly during early morning and late evening hours, and the DURGA scheme was designed with these challenges in mind, aiming to promote safe transport alongside self-employment opportunities.

Of the 1,300 pink electric autos proposed in the first phase, 1,170 will go to women and 130 to transgender beneficiaries. Each revenue

district will get a maximum of 90 electric autos for women and up to 10 for transgender beneficiaries. Applicants can apply through a dedicated online portal created for the scheme, with benefits available to those who meet the prescribed eligibility criteria.

For women applicants, eligibility conditions include an age of 20 to 40 years, Delhi residency, a valid voter identity card, an LMV licence and a PSV badge. The e-autos will carry a mandatory three-year lock-in period, during which they cannot be sold, transferred or disposed of in any other manner. A special arrangement has been proposed to integrate the scheme with the public transport network, with DMRC stating that EV charging space has already been made available in parking areas of 70 metro stations.



SC stays ₹5 lakh fine on Noida DM

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed the operation of the Allahabad High Court order directing Gautam Buddh Nagar District Magistrate Medha Roopam to pay compensation of Rs 5 lakh from her salary for the detention of student Akriti Chaudhary under the NSA in connection with the Noida workers' protest in April.

A bench of Justices Satish Chandra Sharma and N Kotishwar Singh issued notice on Roopam's plea and stayed high court's direction quashing Chaudhary's detention.

The top court passed the interim orders on two separate pleas filed by Roopam and the Uttar Pradesh Government. During the brief hearing, the bench heard Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the district magistrate (DM), and senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi for the state of UP, before it muted the audio of the video conference proceedings. The bench also stayed the observations made in the high court order against the DM. "After hearing senior counsels for the parties, this court is of the opinion that till the matter is heard on merits, the operation of the impugned judgment, particularly, para Nos. 27 to 33 shall remain stayed,"



it ordered and posted the matter for further hearing on October 7.

Senior advocate Collin Gonsalves appeared for Chaudhary on caveat.

On September 2, the high court quashed the detention of Akriti Chaudhary, a 25-year-old Delhi University history graduate, who was taken into custody under the National Security Act (NSA) in connection with the Noida workers' protest in April.

Allowing Chaudhary's habeas corpus petition challenging her arrest, the high court found that the detention was based on a story

"concocted" by the state and directed her immediate release if her arrest was not warranted in any other case.

It strongly criticised the manner in which the detention order was passed by Roopam and warned that continued "despotic" conduct by "errant" bureaucracy could reduce Uttar Pradesh to an "Orwellian dystopia". It also awarded Rs 5 lakh compensation to Chaudhary and directed that the amount be recovered from the salary of Roopam, who passed the detention order, as well as other officers responsible right down to

the SHO. On September 9, Solicitor General Mehta told the Supreme Court that an appeal would be filed against the high court decision quashing the detention order.

Chaudhary was arrested in connection with cases arising from the Noida workers' protest and the Uttar Pradesh Police subsequently invoked NSA against her and activist-journalist Satya Verma on May 13.

They were among several activists arrested in cases relating to the protest seeking higher wages.

In the order, the high court also made several significant observations on the roles of the bureaucracy and the police. It said officers are entrusted with immense powers because they bear responsibility for upholding the constitutional and legal rights, dignity, honour and welfare of citizens.

However, the court stressed that bureaucrats must remember that their "loyalty is towards the Constitution and not the political executive". It further said that officers are servants who serve the people, who are "the masters in a democracy". It directed that the high court's displeasure against the DM and police officers involved in preparing the dossier be recorded in their service records.

PM Modi, council of ministers brainstorm governance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The first day of 'Chintan Shivir' of the entire council of ministers of the Modi Government on Wednesday discussed a host of issues, including governance, reforms and outreach to women and youth on welfare and development schemes, sources said.

During the over four-hour meeting, the ministers also discussed how to further improve the delivery mechanism of the Government with close coordination among different ministries and departments, the sources aware of the deliberations said.

The ministers were divided into eight groups, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacting with each of them, the sources said.

Modi is learnt to have taken feedback from the ministers and advised them on how to go about various aspects of the Government.

The ministers discussed issues related to governance, reforms and outreach to women and youth on welfare and development schemes, the sources said. The other issues that



were deliberated by the ministers included 'Jan Vishwas Se Jan Aadhaar', reforms in all aspects of the Government and priorities towards Viksit Bharat@2047.

The two-day brainstorming session has been called for stocktaking, improving coordination, preparing the future agenda, planning, reviewing the work under way on welfare schemes, and infrastructure projects, among others, the sources said. The exercise of taking stock of different aspects of the Government through such a conclave is expected to be held next week too, they said.

The Viksit Bharat exercise has been underway since 2021, with 10 sectoral groups of secretaries constituted to prepare short-term and long-term roadmaps to

achieve the goal. Vast stakeholder consultation was also done for this exercise.

Since then, there have been eight presentations and discussions before the council of ministers on different aspects of Viksit Bharat@2047.

The ongoing 'Chintan Shivir' takes this process forward, the sources said.

It brings together the work being done by groups of secretaries, ministries and departments, Cabinet Secretariat and NITI Aayog, including reforms, ease of living, reduction of compliances and other governance priorities.

Progress of Government schemes, policy implementation, time management, inter-ministerial coordination and public service delivery are issues that figure in the agenda of

Delhi congress seeks independent audit Of EC's SIR exercise

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Congress on Wednesday demanded an independent audit of the Election Commission's Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in the national capital, alleging that it disproportionately affected people living in JJ clusters and unauthorised colonies.

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav, in a press conference, said the party had raised concerns over the deletion of names and notices issued to voters over discrepancies in electoral records.

Yadav claimed that out of around 1.45 crore voters in Delhi, names of 47.6 lakh people had been deleted and notices issued to 31.6 lakh voters to address discrepancies. He demanded that the deadline for completing the process be extended from September 30 to November 30. "The SIR process should be audited by an impartial agency," Yadav said.



Jamui assault raid uncovers 2003 double murder cold case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

When police arrived at the residence in Jamui to apprehend Nandan Yadav, a suspect involved in a viral video depicting the assault of a minor girl following a roadside altercation, they inadvertently reopened a case involving a double homicide from 23 years prior. Nandan Yadav, a resident of Pratappur village, was detained after being shot in the leg while attempting to escape. He is accused of confronting two Class 10 students on a scooter near Jamui's hilly outskirts on 19 September, during which



he assaulted the boy and molested the girl.

Five individuals have been apprehended in connection with this case, and two minors have been detained.

During his interrogation, authorities discovered that his father, Ganori Yadav, was wanted in connection with a double-murder case from 2003. On 3 April 2003, brothers DP Yadav and Pune Yadav

were killed in Pratappur, under the jurisdiction of the Town police station, following a dispute over contract work.

Their mother, Sansari Devi, filed an FIR naming Ganori Yadav as a suspect. Eleven individuals were accused in the case. Police reports indicate that Ganori was the only suspect who remained at large; the others were either released on bail or convicted.

He faced charges including murder, rioting, unlawful assembly, and offences under the Arms Act and had been absconding since the incident.

Azamgarh triple murder: Accused killed in encounter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Azamgarh

Police shot dead a farmer accused of killing his wife and two priests during a religious ceremony at his home in Azamgarh early Wednesday. The shooting came after a standoff lasting nearly seven hours. During this time, he reportedly threatened his children and shot his young son.

The incident started around 6 pm on Tuesday in Shambhupur village, under the Ahraula police station. Arvind Singh, about 40, came home and saw a multi-day puja underway. Relatives had invited priests to pray for

his late brother Sunil, who was murdered years ago, or because they thought Arvind was troubled by an evil spirit and alcohol use. Arvind reportedly objected to the ritual, asked the priests for their Aadhaar cards, and verbally abused them.

When his wife Babita Singh, 32, objected, Arvind took a licensed revolver and shot her. He also fired at the priests. Babita and two priests, Mahendra Pathak, 60, from Patakhoul, and Akhilesh Mishra, about 50, from ChhitaunaBhattauli, died. The other priests managed to escape.

Arvind then locked himself in a small bedroom with his

three children: his son Shaurya, about eight or nine, daughter Pari, 10, and infant Saanvi. Senior officers, including Azamgarh SSP Anil Kumar and Varanasi Zone ADG Naveen Arora, led negotiations throughout the night. Family members tried to speak to Arvind through the door. Around 12.45 am, a gunshot and the children's screams were heard from inside. Officers said they found Shaurya already wounded and Arvind still holding the revolver. According to police, Arvind fired at them, and they fired back. Arvind and Shaurya were taken to the district hospital, where they died

during treatment around 3:30 a.m. Pari had a minor injury near her elbow. Saanvi was not harmed. Both girls were dehydrated and traumatised after going hours without food or water.

The revolver found in the bedroom was first licensed to Sunil and later transferred to Arvind after Sunil died. Forensic teams treated the house as two connected crime scenes: the courtyard and living area where the first shootings happened, and the bedroom where the standoff took place. They collected the firearm, empty cartridge cases, bloodstained flooring or earth, clothing of the victims, and other items.

Investigators created a site plan showing where shots were fired. Investigators are working to tell apart stun-grenade residue from gunshot evidence so the breach is not confused with the shootings.

All five bodies, Babita, Pathak, Mishra, Shaurya, and Arvind, were sent for post-mortem examination. Autopsies are expected to record entry and exit wounds, the range and direction of fire, and the number of injuries on each victim. Police say Shaurya was shot by his father before they entered the room, but relatives disagree and claim a police bullet may have hit the boy.

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Election panel denies internal rift

In recent months, the Commission has taken numerous decisions, issued instructions, introduced around 40 new initiatives and undertaken many electoral reforms including the conduct of Electoral roll revision (including SIR) across the country. All these decisions are an outcome of the unanimous decisions of the full Commission in the past one year," it added.

The report on differences in the ECI published in *The Indian Express* claimed Sandhu and Joshi have formally objected, on record, at least 14 times over the last 10 months – four times on a single day – to decisions taken and orders issued, they say, without their knowledge. Incidentally, Sandhu's name figured among the people with discrepancies in their SIR forms. In the statement, the poll body also said any operational queries or inputs raised by Commission members during draft stages are part of standard administrative practice aimed at safeguarding voter rights and the suggestions given by the Commissioners were for further improving the electoral processes.

"All official orders, decisions and administrative directions issued by the Commission carry full legal sanctions and follow established statutory procedures under The Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023," the press statement added. The ECI further said it is a constitutional body that functions under the strict mandate of Article 324 of the Constitution, statutory rules and established institutional conventions and the EC operates as a multi-member constitutional body.

ECI selection law to face larger SC Bench

However, having regard to the question on which such difference has arisen, i.e., whether the petitions and the applications should be heard by a Constitution Bench of 5 (five) Judges, a decision by a 3-Judge Bench to resolve which of the two opinions is correct would be of little worth and only delay adjudication of the significant issue(s) that these writ petitions raise," the Bench, which heard the pleas for five days, said.

Justice Datta used a cricket analogy to make a point about who should and should not appoint the umpire – in this case, the CEC and the ECs. An umpire selected by the batting team, even if he gives the correct decision, will always be under a shadow of doubt because he will be perceived as loyal to that team, he opined.

The current law for regulating appointment

procedures of the CEC and the deputies replaced the CJI with a Union Cabinet Minister. The current panel to appoint the CEC and other ECs thus comprises the Prime Minister, the Leader of Opposition and a Cabinet minister.

Justice Datta said, "If free and fair elections are to be ensured, it is axiomatic that the ECI must not only be an independent body but also be seen to act independently... Though the 2023 Act may possibly survive the frontal challenge of not including the CJI in the selection committee. It also has to succeed on the perception test, which this court has repeatedly said is essential."

Elaborating on the panel sought to be constituted by the 2023 law, Justice Datta said the minister nominated by the PM to function as the third member of the selection committee, chaired by the PM, cannot be expected to defy his own nominator and risk his continuation as such nominated member on the committee for all practical purposes. "Even otherwise, the collective responsibility doctrine would preclude the minister from opposing his PM, as observed in the Manoj Narula case (2014 verdict) which reposes faith in the PM, and the entire nation has expectations of good governance being carried on by the ministers of his choice," he said.

He added that since it is the Council of Ministers who has the collective responsibility to sustain the integrity and purity of the constitutional structure, it is far-fetched to expect that a minister who is part of the council and bound by the collective responsibility under Article 75(3) would adopt a stand in the matter of appointment to a sensitive constitutional office disagreeing with the leader of the Government. "In such a circumstance, the inclusion of a Cabinet minister in the selection committee fails to provide the independent counterweight that a neutral selector could, and the cabinet minister would merely echo the voice of his leader, and consequently, the presence of the leader of opposition in the selection committee becomes largely ornamental without furthering the purpose of his inclusion," Justice Datta emphasised.

However, Justice Sharma observed that the issue has to be authoritatively determined by a Constitution Bench in terms of Article 145(3) of the Constitution. Justice Sharma said, "Having regard to the aforesaid discussion, in my opinion, all the petitions in accordance with Article 145(3) of the Constitution and Order 38 of the Supreme Court Rules may now be placed before the Hon'ble Chief Justice of India for an appropriate order of constitution of a Constitution Bench to adjudicate the constitutional validity of Sections 7, 6 and 8 of the said Act".

On March 2, 2023, in a landmark verdict aimed at insulating the appointment of the CEC and ECs from the executive's interference, a five-

judge Constitution bench ruled that their appointments will be made by the president on the advice of a committee comprising the prime minister, the leader of the opposition in the Lok Sabha and the CJI.

The law, enacted by Parliament in December 2023, came months after a landmark verdict by which the apex court directed that election commissioners be appointed by a committee comprising the prime minister, the leader of the opposition and the CJI. The apex court had earlier refused to stay the appointment of new election commissioners under the 2023 law.

India hits back at OIC on J&K

The MEA urged the neighboring state to look inward and take concrete action against the active terrorist infrastructure operating within its borders, rather than attempting to internationalise bilateral matters through external organisations. India has consistently maintained a firm diplomatic stance against third-party commentary on its sovereign territories, repeatedly advising international bodies to respect its territorial integrity and non-interference in domestic affairs.

Global agencies raise India FY27 growth call

The 7.8 per cent growth rate in the June quarter indicates that the Indian economy has shown resilience in the face of the shock from the US-Iran war, despite the strong terms-of-trade deterioration seen in the first half of 2026, Fitch said.

"Despite recent strong momentum, reduced purchasing power is also expected to weaken growth in India through the second half of this year, before a gradual recovery takes place in 2027. In annual terms, growth is projected to fall from 7.8 per cent in fiscal year (FY) 2025-26 to 7.1 per cent in FY 2026-27 and 6.5 per cent in FY 2027-28," OECD said.

OECD's GDP growth projection of 7.1 per cent for FY27 is the highest among other international agencies. "Amongst the emerging-market economies, India is projected to raise policy rates temporarily to help offset stronger inflationary pressures," said the OECD Economic Outlook Interim report.

It said global economic prospects remain "heavily dependent" on whether a durable resolution to the Middle East conflict is achieved. At the current juncture, countries will have to undertake structural policy reforms that enhance their ability to cope with supply-side disruptions, it added.

The economy has also benefited from lower-than-expected supply disruptions, sustained

capital inflows, and limited pass-through of higher input costs to consumer prices, which helped cushion the impact of the conflict in the Middle East, the Asian Development Outlook report said.

ADB Country Director for India Mio Oka said that despite supply disruptions and high commodity prices, India's economy continues to demonstrate resilience, supported by strong infrastructure spending and growth-supporting fiscal and monetary policies.

Nitin Nabin rejigs BJP machinery ahead...

"All these appointments made by BJP president Nitin Nabin come into effect immediately," the party said in an order. Former BJP IT cell and its social media chief Amit Malviya alongside Sadanand Shet Tanawade and Kamaljeet Sehrawat have been named co-in-charges for Maharashtra.

Senior BJP leader Vinay Sahasrabudhe will serve as the in-charge for Delhi, while Jamyang Tsering Namgyal and Darshana Jardosh will be the co-in-charges.

In another state that will go to polls next year, Punjab, Satish Poonia has been named the in-charge, with former Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva and Rajya Sabha MP Alka Gurljar as co-in-charges. Poonia has also been appointed in-charge for Jammu and Kashmir.

Goa has Dr Bharti Pravin Pawar as in-charge and Anil Antony as co-in-charge. Manipur has Dr Rajdeep Roy as in-charge.

In West Bengal, Sunil Bansal will be assisted by Lal Singh Arya, Rajendra Singh and Pinki Kushwaha. Odisha will be handled by D Purandeswari, with Dr Swadesh Singh as co-in-charge. Assam has Mangal Pandey as in-charge and Phangnon Konyak as co-in-charge. Former Tripura chief minister Biplav Kumar Deb has been made the in-charge for Madhya Pradesh, while ex-Union minister Bharati Pravin Pawar has been assigned Goa. The coastal state goes to polls next year. In the Northeast, Dr Devesh Kumar has been appointed in Arunachal Pradesh, Raju Bista in Sikkim, Kanad Purkayastha and Dr Nimal Momin in Meghalaya, Dr Bhagwat Karad in Mizoram, Anil Antony in Nagaland and Mriganka Dev Burman in Tripura.

Among the Union Territories, Jai Prakash has been appointed in Andaman and Nicobar, Manoj Tigga in Chandigarh, Varshaben Narendrabhai Doshi in Dadra and Nagar Haveli, Daman and Diu, Rajkumar Bhatia in Ladakh, and George Kurian in Lakshadweep. In Jammu and Kashmir, Satish Poonia will be assisted by Reena Kashyap.

Lok Sabha MP D Purandeswari has been assigned Odisha, with national secretary Swadesh Singh as the co-in-charge. BJP MLA from

Assam, Rajeev Roy, has been assigned Manipur, another state where elections are due next year.

BJP defends Gyanesh Kumar as Opposition...

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters, party spokesperson Sambit Patra said, "The media reports saying that the election commissioners shared differing views in official deliberations is a reflection of pure democracy." "If there is no communication and exchange of views among the election commissioners who conduct polls, the opposition parties would allege dictatorship and call them yes-men of the Government," he charged.

"All opposition parties, who have been calling the EC and the Government dictatorial, have fallen into their own trap today," Patra added, slamming the Opposition parties for levelling baseless allegations against the poll panel and the Government.

The Opposition parties, which have been critical of the ECI and the CEC over SIR, are demanding impeachment of CEC Kumar in Parliament. Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, reiterated his charge of vote theft against the ECI, terming it an act of treason and a crime against the people of India. "The BJP, RSS and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served," Gandhi said.

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal demanded that CEC Gyanesh Kumar should be jailed and immediately removed from his post. Thackeray demanded that CEC Gyanesh Kumar be jailed and that the last elections in Maharashtra, West Bengal and Tamil Nadu be nullified and repolls be held in these states using ballot papers.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said that on April 24, 73 Opposition Rajya Sabha MPs had submitted a new Notice of Motion to the Secretary General to remove CEC Kumar.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said the Union Government and the ECI need to take corrective steps in order to prevent people from losing faith in the elections. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav said in Lucknow that Governments formed during a period when the ECI was not functioning impartially were "unconstitutional", and that the "interference" with the poll panel amounted to "trampling" democracy.

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) also demanded an immediate halt to the SIR process, and the removal of Kumar. CPI general secretary D Raja said CEC Gyanesh Kumar must resign over "Electoral purge". Mamata Banerjee-led TMC faction leader Abhishek Banerjee too demanded the removal of CEC Kumar and sought a court-monitored investigation into the functioning of the poll panel.

CM Satheesan defends inquiry into charges against ex-Kerala CM, family

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Keralam Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Wednesday defended the State Government's decision to order an inquiry into allegations against CPI(M) leader Pinarayi Vijayan and his family in connection with the CMRL-Exalogic case, saying it was based on legal advice and Supreme Court judgments and was not aimed at targeting anyone.

He was reacting to a query at a press conference here on his Government's decision to order a police inquiry based on the ED's report to it seeking action against former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter Veena T and her husband PA Mohamed Riyas in the alleged CMRL bribery case.

The ED had sought registration of an FIR against Vijayan, his kin and others in connection with allegations arising from financial transactions involving CMRL and Exalogic. The Congress-led Government's latest decision is to proceed with an inquiry rather than directly register an FIR.

Satheesan said the Government had carried out the required legal scrutiny before taking the decision.

"It is the Government's legal obligation to take such



Keralam Chief Minister VD Satheesan

a decision, and that decision has now been taken," he said.

Rejecting the CPI(M)'s allegation of political vendetta, the Chief Minister said, "This Government is not acting with the intention of targeting or going after anyone, or acting out of a sense of revenge. As I said, the law will take its own course."

Slamming the Government decision, the CPI(M) alleged that a strange situation had emerged in which the state Government appeared to be joining hands with the Narendra Modi-led Government to target the Left party.

Satheesan said that those facing the inquiry would have all legal rights to present their side during the investigation.

"When the law takes its own course, everyone will have all the rights available to them. During the investiga-

tion, they will have every right to present their side and make whatever submissions they wish to make," he said.

Defending the Government decision, Satheesan said the Government had received a letter from the Enforcement Directorate under Section 66(2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), which was forwarded to the DGP and subsequently to the Home Department.

The Government then sought legal opinions from the Advocate General and the Director General of Prosecution.

"We received a letter under Section 66(2) of the PML Act. We handed over that letter to the DGP. The DGP forwarded it to the Home Minister. The Home Minister discussed it with the Chief Minister, and we referred the matter for legal opinion," Satheesan said.

He said the legal opinion referred to a Supreme Court judgment on Section 66(2), under which information shared by the ED with the jurisdictional police has to be acted upon in accordance with law. The Government has now ordered a preliminary inquiry into allegations against Vijayan, kin and others based on the ED's report. The inquiry is expected to be conducted by a Crime Branch special investigation team.

"The legal opinion clearly referred to a Supreme Court judgment. Under Section 66(2), if the matter is handed over to the jurisdictional police, the jurisdictional police here means the Kerala Police. The Kerala Police can conduct an investigation, and the Supreme Court has made it mandatory that an investigation should be conducted," he said.

The CM also referred to the Supreme Court's judgment in the Lalita Kumari case, saying it laid down guidelines on preliminary inquiry before registration of an FIR in certain categories of cases.

"So, there are two important Supreme Court judgments applicable here. In accordance with these judgments, the police have to first conduct an inquiry and then take a decision. That is a legal obligation," he said.

IIT Bombay sets up panel to probe student's suicide, Doolla sent on leave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai/New Delhi

IIT Bombay on Wednesday set up a 10-member high-level committee to probe the circumstances surrounding the alleged suicide of B Tech student Sahil Wakode, an official said.

Some TV channels on Wednesday aired CCTV footage from the examination hall that captured Sahil's movements before a professor approaches him and leads him away from the hall after he was allegedly caught copying. However, Mumbai Police Crime Branch, which is probing the case, has not commented on the viral footage.

Sahil's father Ravindra said he would begin a hunger strike if the IIT Bombay officials named in the case FIR were not arrested.

Faculty member Suryanarayan Doolla, named in the FIR, which alleges abetment to suicide on grounds of caste discrimination, has been sent on leave to facilitate an impartial probe into the case, sources said.

Police appealed to the

public and media to refrain from speculation, spreading misinformation or drawing premature conclusions in connection with Sahil's death.

MNS president Raj Thackeray said caste is a "favourite topic" for those driven by power politics and students should not get entangled in it, after allegations of caste-based discrimination linked to the suicide of an IIT Bombay student.

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) demanded a thorough investigation into the case and stressed that action should be taken against whoever is found responsible after the probe.

The probe panel, constituted by the board of Indian Institute of Technology Bombay on Wednesday, was also likely to question Doolla, an official said. The Mumbai Police Crime Branch is already conducting a probe into the death of Sahil, who was found hanging in his hostel room on the evening of September 18, hours after being caught while allegedly using a mobile phone to access ChatGPT during a mid-



Ravindra Wakode and Sonali Wakode, parents of IIT Bombay student Sahil Wakode, interact with media personnel after visiting the Crime Branch office in connection with their son's death case in Mumbai

PTI

semester examination.

Mumbai Police, in a statement, assured that the investigation was being conducted "diligently and impartially, exploring all possible angles."

"Mumbai Police appeals to individuals and the public to refrain from speculation, spreading misinformation, or drawing premature conclusions. Media is requested to follow information transmitted through official channels only," the statement said.

The police are committed to a fair and thorough investigation to ensure justice is

served, it said. Wakode's parents have claimed that he had told them about the caste-based slurs he faced. They demanded the immediate arrest of IIT Bombay Director Shirish Kedare and Doolla, who has been removed as the dean of Administrative Affairs following protests by students and political activists.

Describing Sahil's death as deeply unfortunate, Raj Thackeray, in a post on X, said no one seems to be discussing the reason why he felt compelled to resort to suicide.

"Sahil's death occurred due to flaws within the education system. Addressing these issues would be a fitting tribute to him and the many others like him who took their own lives, unable to bear the stress," the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief said. "Caste is a favourite topic for those interested in power politics; students should not get entangled in it. On the contrary, they should show such politicians their true place," Thackeray stated. "It appears that the weapon of caste and religion is being used to ensnare you and divert your attention from the core issues, specifically to prevent anyone from speaking out against or protesting the flaws in our Government machinery," he said.

Doolla has been sent on leave to enable an impartial probe, with no classes currently underway, the sources said.

On Sahil's death, ABVP national general secretary Virendra Singh Solanki told PTI that taking any action without a detailed understanding of the matter and ascertaining the truth would not be appropriate.

MHA makes significant progress in grievance redressal and preparedness for special campaign

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) made significant progress in reducing administrative backlogs and improving working conditions between November 2025 and August 2026; it addressed more than 59,000 public complaints and appeals, demonstrating its efforts to make offices more efficient. The Ministry officially recorded settling 52,050 grievances and 7,410 appeals.

Citizens raise complaints when they ask the Ministry to address specific problems, while appeals are made when people believe previous decisions were incomplete or unsatisfactory. The fact that a large number of cases in both types are being resolved indicates that the Ministry is working to respond more quickly and reduce the number of unresolved cases.

In addition to addressing citizen complaints, the Ministry fulfilled 299 requests from Members of Parliament, 336 from state Governments, and seven from the Prime Minister's Office. Requests from Parliament and state Governments usually require interdepartmental coordination, preparation of field reports, or clarity on policy



matters. Although the Prime Minister's Office made only a small number of requests, the Ministry gave them top priority because they generally concern important issues raised at the highest level of Government.

The Ministry has, in general, dealt with public petitions and official requests as part of an initiative to reduce the number of pending cases, and it is sharing these results as it prepares to take part in Special Campaign 6, organised by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances.

The campaign aims to reduce outstanding work, improve record-keeping, and encourage cleanliness in Government offices. Preparations will take place between 15 and 30 September 2026, and imple-

mentation will take place from 2 to 31 October 2026.

Amit Shah, the Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation, has instructed that special attention be given to field and outstation offices that work directly with the public. The Ministry said Special Campaign 6 will focus on creating sustainable, eco-friendly workplaces and reducing pending cases across various areas. Work to improve physical workplaces has already begun.

In the same ten-month period, the Ministry and its associated organisations conducted 761 cleanliness campaigns. The Ministry's offices, together with the Central Armed Police Forces, cleared an area of 1,02,084 square feet. The recovered space can now be used for organised record storage, better seating, and more

practical arrangements, supporting both cleanliness and daily operations.

The Central Armed Police Forces and the Central Police Organisations have been informed of the campaign's significance and urged to make greater efforts to achieve its objectives. A portal operated by the Ministry coordinates the various activities. All the divisions, including those in the Union Territories and the Delhi Police, upload their campaign data onto this platform.

This arrangement enables the central authority to monitor cleanliness activities, the use of space, and progress in reducing the number of pending cases throughout the Ministry's extensive network. Among the Ministry's recent accomplishments are the resolution of a large number of grievances, appeals, and official requests; the organisation of hundreds of cleanliness drives; and the recovery of more than one lakh square feet of office space. The improvements from a focus on field units will become apparent in areas where the public comes into contact with the Ministry as Special Campaign 6 moves from preparation to implementation in October 2026.

Rahul demands implementation of 27% OBC reservation in MP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Congress president Rahul Gandhi has written to Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav, urging him to implement 27 per cent reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBC) in the state and clear the way for pending appointments under it.

In the letter, Gandhi said that during his Chhatron Ki Gunj event in Indore on Saturday, numerous students from Madhya Pradesh raised several serious issues concerning education, employment and their future.

A prominent issue highlighted was the stalling of appointments linked to OBC reservation, he said in the letter dated September 22.

"They (students) expressed that they have been facing constant uncertainty about their future due to these long-delayed appointments. Although these young candidates have passed the examinations and completed the entire selection process, 13 per



cent of the posts earmarked under the OBC reservation quota have been kept on hold due to the '87:13' formula; consequently, the selected candidates have been waiting for their appointments since 2022," Gandhi said.

All political parties had unanimously supported 27 per cent OBC reservation, yet, the issue remains unresolved, he said. "Due to this delay, candidates are repeatedly compelled to take to the streets to demand the implementation of OBC reservation and the issuance of their appointment letters," he said.

Posting his letter on X, Gandhi said, "During the

Chhatron ki Goonj programme in Indore, students from the OBC category reported that even though the selection process is complete, appointments to 13 per cent of the posts under the 27 per cent OBC reservation have been stalled for years." "The students are in great distress... The precious time of these young people, who have been waiting for more than four years, should not be wasted any further," he said. "Please hear their plea, implement the 27 per cent OBC reservation that was passed unanimously by all parties, and provide appointments to all the selected candidates," Gandhi said.

NCPI to support BJP in West Bengal bypolls

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The Nationalist Citizens Party, recently strengthened by 20 defecting MPs from the Trinamool Congress, will now support the BJP in its by-election campaign for the Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly seats. The elections are scheduled for October 6. Jyotiprakash Chattopadhyay, the newly elected president of a 27-member committee of NCPI office bearers, on Wednesday said that as a part of the NDA, his party had decided to campaign for the BJP.

"We had taken part in the recent all-party meeting convened by our Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji... We joined the meeting as an NDA constituent... By dint of our numbers we are now the second largest party in the NDA... we will take part in the election campaign as and when the BJP requests us," Chattopadhyay said.

The BJP welcomed Chattopadhyay's statement, dismissing any speculation about a future electoral alliance or seat-sharing mechanism with the party.

State party spokesperson Sayantan Bose said, "we welcome their gesture... But that does not mean that we have any kind of electoral alliance or any future seat-sharing formula should be deduced from their



good gesture."

Basu's statement assumes significance in the backdrop of looming civic elections in Bengal, which are likely to take place sometime in November or December, when Howrah and Kolkata Municipal Corporations go to polls. His statement echoed the one recently made by State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya, who said that his party "has no plans to fight jointly... We intend to contest the civic elections alone."

In the Assembly by-elections for which the campaigns have already started, the BJP has fielded Hansirani Rath — a former panchayat member and the mother of Chandranath Rath, the slain personal assistant of Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari — from Nandigram. In contrast, Sakharav Sarkar, the

Murshidabad district president of BJP, is contesting from Rejinagar.

While Hindus constitute just about 32 per cent of the the Murshidabad electorate, in Nandigram they are in the majority, with more than 75 per cent of votes.

When asked to comment on former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's Gaddar (traitor) barb on the NCPI MPs who had broken away from the TMC post-BJP's victory in the April-May Assembly elections in Bengal, Chattopadhyay said, "Do they have any locus standi to say so... Is there any party existing called Trinamool Congress... They are bringing anti-defection charges... But their party has split up... It does not exist as of now... So, when there is no party by such a name, where is the question of any defection?

Mamata demands fresh polls, action against CEC

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Former Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has demanded action against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and holding of fresh elections in the State following reports in a national English daily that several decisions — including the deletion of names of voters via Special Intensive Revision of the electoral rolls — were implemented overruling the opposition of other two Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi.

Airing her grievances on



social media, Banerjee on Wednesday said that as it had been proved that the "EC

and BJP jointly looted votes" in the April-May Assembly elections, fresh elections

Drug-free West Bengal top priority, says CM Suwendu

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The top priority of his Government was to make Bengal a drug-free State, as drugs were the cog behind the wheels of crime, Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said on Wednesday.

The Chief Minister, who personally took part in destroying more than 3 lakh bottles of a banned cough syrup at Eco Park in Rajar Haat New Town, said his Government was actively working towards making a "Nasha Mukh Bengal" (drug-free Bengal) without which a

Nasha Mukh Bharat was not possible.

The Wednesday programme was initiated by Bidhannagar Police, when more than 3.10 lakh bottles worth Rs 31 crore were destroyed. The programme was part of the Union Govt's anti-drug campaign under the "Nasha mukh Bharat" — by 2029 — program.

"Drug is the one of the prime contributing factors behind crimes, including crimes against women... We have found that drug is the main contributing factor behind criminal activities like the one that took place



at Baruipur (where a minor girl was gang-raped by a group of felons, one of whom was subsequently killed in an encounter)," Adhikari said,

reminding how drug was ruining families.

"In the past five months since we came to power, we have noticed how drugs

are ruining many families and society as a whole... So we have made it our top priority to end drug addiction in West Bengal," he said adding apart from the State police several agencies like the BSF, STF NCB the Kolkata Police were also actively taking part in the programme.

It was such joint operations that were bringing the Government a lot of success in the drug eradication programme, he said, informing how a peddler from Assam was recently arrested, and Yaba tablets were recovered from him.



States Focus



MURMU URGES STUDENTS TO PUT NATION, SOCIETY FIRST

President Droupadi Murmu on Wednesday urged students to keep the interests of the nation and society paramount in their field of work, saying they would progress along with the country and society.

Addressing students at the 75th convocation of Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda here, Murmu also highlighted the rising participation of women in higher education and said their increasing presence in every field was a positive sign of India's inclusive development. She said students should think beyond using their education for themselves and their families and consider how they could contribute to the larger good. (PTI)



BJP SUBVERTING FOUNDATIONS OF DEMOCRACY: MEHBOOBA

Former Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Mehbooba Mufti on Wednesday cautioned that India risks resembling a "banana republic" if the "fudging" of electoral rolls to suit the ruling BJP goes unchecked.

The PDP president was reacting to an Indian Express report that two Election Commissioners had objected to the Election Commission's steps 14 times in 10 months amid the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voters list.

Officials said Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had flagged multiple issues, including deletion of names, in various states during the voter roll cleanup but the poll body was unanimous in its decisions related to the pan-India SIR. "I feel that both our sibling nations – India and Pakistan – are trying to undo each other, competing with each other over who can cause more harm to their own people, to their country," Mehbooba told reporters here, drawing parallels between the two neighbouring nations. (PTI)

Meghalaya: 8 UDP MLAs switch to BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday got a shot in the arm with eight MLAs of Meghalaya's United Democratic Party (UDP) joining it in the presence of senior leaders, including Union minister Kiren Rijiju at the party headquarters. Lahkmen Rymbui, Pius Marwein, Kyrmien Shylla, Mayralborn Syiem, Matthew Kurbah, Ollan Singh Suin, Balajied Kupar Synrem and Synshar Kupar Roy joined BJP in New Delhi.

The UDP has 12 MLAs in the 60-member Assembly, two of whom are ministers in the Conrad K Sangma-led Meghalaya Democratic Alliance Government. With eight of the UDP legislators switching sides, the BJP's strength in the 60-member assembly increased from two to 10. It would give the BJP more influence over ministerial representation and policy priorities, as the State heads to the Assembly election in 2028. Both the UDP and BJP are currently allies of the NPP-led Government.

Welcoming the UDP MLAs to the party, Rijiju said they have joined the BJP looking



BJP National President Nitin Nabin along with Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju present as 8 MLAs of Meghalaya's United Democratic Party (UDP) join the party during an event at the party headquarters in New Delhi

at the progress of the north-east and Meghalaya under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"It is an extremely important political development, not only for the northeast but the entire country. It is a defining moment for Meghalaya," the senior BJP leader said at a joint press conference at the BJP headquarters. "All of these eight MLAs were extremely impressed and influenced by Prime Minister Modi and our BJP-led NDA Government's performance. They decided to join the BJP," Rijiju added.

UDP SUSPENDS 3 OF 8 MLAs

Shillong: The United Democratic Party (UDP) suspended three of its eight MLAs who joined the BJP, as the regional party in Meghalaya began disciplinary action against legislators who crossed over to the saffron party, party president Metbah Lyngdoh said. The action came hours after the eight UDP MLAs joined the BJP following a meeting of the party's state parliamentary board, chaired by Lyngdoh.

He said the party had issued show-cause notices to the three legislators after they publicly announced their

decision to join other political parties. "We gave them time until today to appear personally before the state parliamentary board or submit a written reply if they wished. However, none of these members responded to the show-cause notice," he said. "The party unanimously decided to suspend these three members until further orders," Lyngdoh said.

The suspended legislators are Mawsynram MLA Olan Sing Suin, Khliehriat MLA Kyrmien Shylla and Mawphlang MLA Matthew Beyondstar Kurbah. (PNS)

Telangana urges Karnataka CM Shivakumar to release Krishna water to save crops

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Tourism Minister Jupally Krishna Rao and several ruling Congress MLAs have urged Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar to release Krishna river water from the State's reservoirs to save crops in downstream Telangana.

The delegation met Shivakumar in Bengaluru on Tuesday evening and told him that the crops in the command area of Jurala, Nettekpadu, Bhima and Koilsagar projects in Telangana were at a crucial stage and needed water for further growth.

The delegation said that



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar

crops are cultivated in about 5.5 lakh acres under the four irrigation projects and requested Karnataka to release 5,000 cusecs of water for a month to save the crops, an official release said late on Tuesday.

It said Shivakumar

responded positively to their request. The Telangana Government's request came amid protests by farmers in the command area of Jurala project in Jogulamba Gadwal district of Telangana, neighbouring Karnataka for release of water to save their

crops. While BRS held protests on September 21 on the issue, state BJP president N Ramchander Rao was stopped on September 22 while on his way to meet the farmers in Jogulamba Gadwal district.

Noting that the capacity of the Jurala project is over nine TMC, Tourism Minister Jupally Krishna Rao has earlier said about three TMC of water is in silt, while another three TMC is meant for meeting drinking water needs till the end of June, 2027. Responding to BRS criticism, the minister sought to know why the previous BRS Government did not build reservoirs for additional water storage.

UCC to permanently polarise society: Congress

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Wednesday alleged that for the Modi Government, the UCC is not an instrument of considered legal reform but an instrument of division, disruption and diversion, as well as a tool for stoking prejudices and keeping society in a State of permanent polarisation.

The Opposition party's assertion comes after former Bombay High Court judge Justice RC Chavan resigned from the Maharashtra Government's panel to prepare a draft for implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), citing serious reservations over its decision to restrict public feedback on crucial social issues to a "Yes/No" format.

Congress general secretary-in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh said the resignation of a former high court judge from the



Congress leader Jairam Ramesh

Maharashtra Government's committee to draft a UCC for the state raises larger questions, apart from his several concerns on the functioning of this committee.

Posting his statement on X, Ramesh said, "A retired High Court judge has shown courage to resign from a committee set up by the Maharashtra Government to prepare a uniform civil code for the State. Here is our statement on the non-uniform 'Uniform' Civil Codes (UCC) the HM is trying to bulldoze through in every State."

"Did the Constituent Assembly ever imagine a situation in which every State would enact its own separate version of a UCC? The answer is a resounding no," Ramesh said.

Did the architects of our Constitution led by Dr BR Ambedkar ever conceive states competing with one another to have different UCCs according to the political machinations and calculations of one political party, he asked.

"Again, the answer is a resounding no," Ramesh

added. He pointed out that on June 17, 2016, the Modi Government referred the question of the UCC to the 21st Law Commission of India for detailed examination.

"After extensive research, the Commission published its Consultation Paper on Reform of Family Law on August 31, 2018. Its conclusion appearing in paragraph 1.15 on page 7 of the Consultation Paper was clear: 'The formulation of a Uniform Civil Code is neither necessary nor desirable at this stage'. Instead it recommended addressing nor discrimination within individual family laws while preserving India's legal and cultural diversity," Ramesh said.

The Modi Government has chosen to disregard the findings of the very Commission it tasked with examining the issue because the facts, as usual, did not align with its political agenda, the Congress leader said.

Telangana hospital fire: Infants toll rises to five

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

The toll in the fire accident in the SNCU of the state-run RIMS in Adilabad district, rose to five after two more infants died on Wednesday, police said.

Three babies died after the fire broke out late on Monday in the air-conditioning unit of the Special Newborn Care Unit (SNCU), apparently due to a short circuit. Thick smoke spread through the unit after plastic parts of the AC caught fire.

Twenty-seven infants

undergoing treatment in the unit were shifted to different private hospitals.

One pre-term baby was declared brought dead, and two others died on Tuesday. "Two more infants succumbed on Wednesday, taking the death toll to five," a senior police official said. Four others were taken home by their parents after



their condition became stable, officials earlier said.

State Health Minister C Damodar Rajanarasimha, who visited the hospital on Tuesday, said an expert committee would conduct a comprehensive inquiry into the cause of the fire, lapses in safety and administration, and suggest measures to prevent such incidents.

Meanwhile, Telangana Human Rights Commission (TGHR) Chairperson Shameem Akther, taking cog-

BJP lauds eight years of Ayushman Bharat scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Wednesday lauded the eight years of the Ayushman Bharat scheme, saying more than 60 crore beneficiaries across all 36 States and Union territories are receiving annual health cover of up to ₹5 lakh.

Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana (AB-PMJAY) was launched on September 23, 2018, to provide cashless hospitalisation cover of up to ₹5 lakh per family annually for secondary and tertiary care. It is the financial protection component of the broader Ayushman Bharat programme. The programme also includes Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, which seek to strengthen comprehensive primary healthcare, along with the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission and the Pradhan Mantri Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission.

In a post on social media, BJP national president Nitin Nabin said the scheme, launched under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has opened a new chapter in making healthcare security more accessible to citizens across the country. "Through Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY, more than 60 crore beneficiaries across all 36 States and Union Territories are receiving annual health cover of up to ₹5 lakh," he said.



BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari

He said more than 1.86 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandirs across the country have also brought over 500 crore healthcare visits closer to communities.

"Ayushman Bharat continues to move forward with the vision of a healthier citizen and a stronger Bharat," Nabin added.

BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari said beneficiaries under the scheme do not have to pay for treatment up to ₹5 lakh and described the initiative as a major welfare measure of the Narendra Modi Government. He said more than 13 crore hospital admissions have taken place under the scheme and claimed that the figure is "globally number one".

"This is welfare. This is Prime Minister Narendra Modi's impact," Bhandari said in a post. Bhandari also said more than ₹2 lakh crore have been spent under the scheme, claiming that it showed the impact of the Modi Government's development initiatives on the ground. He contrasted the scheme with the healthcare system under previous Congress Governments, saying people earlier had to pay for their treatment and did not have access to Ayushman cards. "Today, eight years of Ayushman Bharat have been completed. Till ₹5 lakh, zero money, all health insurance by the Government of India," Bhandari said.

Ruckus in Odisha Assembly over textbook errors

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bhubaneswar

Opposition MLAs on Wednesday created a ruckus in the Odisha Assembly demanding the resignation of School and Mass Education Minister Nityananda Gond over errors in school textbooks, leading to the adjournment of the House till 4 pm.

As soon as the House assembled for Question Hour at 10:30 am on the second day of the monsoon session, BJD and Congress members, holding placards, trooped into the well and staged an agitation near the Speaker's podium demanding the resignation of the minister and the repeal of the new mining law. The BJD members raised the issue of errors in textbooks, while the Congress MLAs demanded the repeal of the MMDR Act.

While a section of the agitating members stood on the reporters' table, another group tried to climb onto the Speaker's podium.

The treasury bench members were seen silently sitting in their seats even as Opposition members raised anti-Government slogans in the well. The agitation gained intensity when Deputy Speaker Bhabani Shankar Bhoi, who was presiding over the proceedings, allowed Science and Technology Minister KC Patra to respond to the opposition members' queries. Bhoi's appeal to the agitating members to return to their seats fell on deaf ears, prompting the deputy speaker to adjourn the House till 4 pm within five minutes of functioning.



Defence ministry inks contract with BDL for anti-airfield weapons

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The defence ministry on Wednesday inked a contract worth ₹810.79 crore with Bharat Dynamics Limited (BDL) for the procurement of 160 Satellite Smart Anti-Airfield Weapons (SAT-SAAW) along with associated equipment for the Indian Air Force (IAF) under the Buy (Indian - Indigenously Designed, Developed and Manufactured) category.

Giving details, the ministry said the contract was signed in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh here. SAT-SAAW is an air-ground precision-guided glide bomb which can be launched from platforms like Jaguar, Hawk & Su-30 MKI, and has the capability to neutralise enemy airfields from a long stand-off range. Indigenously designed and



developed by DRDO, the system will have an indigenous content of 60 per cent along with indigenous sub-systems like Initial Measurement Unit, Long Impact Delay Fuse and Twin Store Carrier to further boost Aatmanirbharta in defence.

The delivery of SAT-SAAW is scheduled between 2027-2028 and 2028-2029. Its induction would certainly enhance the operational capability of the IAF to continue its unhindered operations and strengthen defence preparedness.

Traders in Madhya Pradesh cover QR codes with black cloth protesting MDR on UPI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Indore

Traders across Madhya Pradesh observed a 'No UPI Day' on Wednesday to protest the Union Government's decision to impose a 0.4 per cent fee on UPI transactions over Rs 2,000 by covering the QR codes at their shops with black cloth.

The protesters appealed to their customers to make payments in cash.

Ramesh Khandelwal, president of the Ahilya Chamber of Commerce and Industry, a federation of trade organisations, claimed that their members in Indore, Bhopal, Jabalpur, Gwalior, Ratlam, Neemuch, Mandsaur, and Jaora participated in the 'No UPI Day'



Representational image

campaign. According to the central Government, a merchant discount rate (MDR) of 0.4 per cent will be levied on person-to-merchant transactions above ₹2,000 from October 15. However, no MDR is to be levied on UPI transactions up to ₹2,000.

Khandelwal said, "Traders are not against the Government, but their question is, if the money collected from MDR is not going to

the Government treasury, why is this additional burden being placed on traders?" According to Khandelwal, who represents Madhya Pradesh on the National Traders Welfare Board, a central Government advisory body, nearly 125 business organisations in Indore, the State's financial capital, participated in the 'No UPI Day' campaign.

Citing the broader inter-

ests of traders and consumers, Akshay Jain, president of the Indore Retail Garments Association, said the Centre should immediately withdraw the decision to impose a 0.4 per cent MDR on UPI transactions exceeding ₹2,000.

If this decision is not withdrawn before October 15, traders will "immerse UPI QR code machines" in water bodies, he said.

The Government has clarified that customers will not be charged any additional amount due to the changes to the UPI (Unified Payments Interface) system, which remained completely free-free for nearly six years. "Customers will not have to pay any fee for making such payments through UPI," the Finance Ministry has said.

CPI, CPI(M) demand resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A major political storm erupted over the functioning of the Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday, with the Left parties demanding the immediate resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and an instant halt to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process.

The joint attack from the Communist Party of India (CPI) and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] comes in the backdrop of media reports reveal-

ing that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi formally recorded objections at least 14 times in the last 10 months against decisions taken under CEC Kumar. The two commissioners had flagged concerns regarding centralisation of the electoral roll database, modifications to voter forms, and voter addition and deletion protocols, even approaching the Cabinet Secretary over the centralisation of control.

In a statement issued on Wednesday, the CPI National Secretariat claimed that over 13 crore voters across States



and Union Territories were removed during the SIR exercise after objections by the two election commissioners were allegedly overridden.

"The CPI has consistently warned that Governments cannot be allowed to hand-pick voters in a democracy. CEC Gyanesh Kumar has become the face of the electoral purge, eroding public trust in the constitutional body. He has no right to continue," the CPI stated, urging the Supreme Court to examine the ECI's decision-making process. The party also linked the current crisis to the Union Government's

2023 legislation altering the appointment procedure for CECs and ECs.

Echoing similar concerns, the CPI(M) Politburo declared that the disclosures have severely damaged the credibility and integrity of the poll body.

"According to the law, all three election commissioners are equal, and any difference should be settled by a majority or unanimity. The CEC didn't follow this rule, but went on imposing his views without caring for the objections raised by his other ECI colleagues," the CPI(M) said. The CPI(M) demanded an

immediate halt to the SIR process and called for a revised appointment mechanism for election commissioners comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition, and the Chief Justice of India, in line with Supreme Court guidelines.

Meanwhile, official sources in the ECI defended the functioning of the panel, maintaining that all decisions taken by the ECI — including those related to the SIR exercise — were made unanimously with the concurrence and approval of both Election Commissioners and the Chief Election Commissioner.

Leh violence: Ladakh LG Saxena drops cases against 20 people

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Lieutenant Governor, Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, on Wednesday approved the withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 individuals related to the unfortunate violence that erupted in Leh on September 24, 2025.

The announcement came on the eve of the first anniversary of the Leh violence, in which four people were killed.

In a post on X, the Office of LG Ladakh said, In the larger interest of peace, public tranquillity, and social harmony in Ladakh, I have approved the withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 individuals related to the unfortunate violence that erupted in



Ladakh LG Vinai Kumar Saxena

Leh on September 24 last year.

According to an official statement posted on X, "Following a comprehensive review, the Ladakh police recommended a closure report for 20 individuals, in FIR no. 144/2005, registered at PS - Leh, under

section 360 of the BNSS".

LG, Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, in a post on X, said, "I extend my sincere gratitude to Union Home Minister Amit Shah for his constant guidance and sympathetic approach in matters related to the victims and their families.

When differences within ECI had tumbled out in open in past

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The differences between the election commissioners over the ongoing SIR have brought to the fore various past cases where members of the poll authority had divergent views which came out in the open.

In 2009, then chief election commissioner (CEC) N Gopalaswami sought the removal of fellow commissioner late Navin Chawla over alleged partisan conduct. The Government rejected the recommendation, and Chawla went on to become CEC.

An even sharper clash preceded this one. Between 1993 and 1995, then CEC late TN Seshan went to court to challenge the creation of a multi-member Commission, leading to a legal battle with fellow commissioners MS Gill and GVG Krishnamurthy.

After his term as CEC ended, Gill joined the Congress and was made a Union minister.

During the 2019 Lok Sabha elections, then election commissioner Ashok Lavasa had given dissent notes on clean chits to top BJP leaders over alleged model code violations.

He had demanded that the dissent notes be included on record in the final published



order. But noting that executive orders of the ECI do not provide for attaching dissent notes to final decisions, the Commission, then headed by Sunil Arora, turned down his demand.

Lavasa later resigned from ECI to join the Asian Development Bank (ADB).

In May 2021, then election commissioner Rajiv Kumar, who later became the CEC, attempted to file a separate affidavit with the Madras High Court and the Supreme Court, defending the poll body against a court observation.

The Madras High Court made the observations, saying the Election Commission was "singularly responsible" for the second wave of the COVID-19 pandemic because of its handling of Assembly elections.

Then CEC Sushil Chandra opposed the affidavit Kumar wanted to file. Their differences came out in the open

and made headlines.

The poll authority is again under fire after incumbent Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi red-flagged a variety of issues, including the deletion of voters in the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the voters' list, and raised objections to the decision-making process 14 times in the past few months. In response, the Election Commission said differing views and observations are a normal part of deliberation in any institution, and that all its orders "are an outcome of the unanimous decisions of the full Commission in the past one year".

The opposition parties, which have been critical of the ECI over the SIR of electoral rolls, latched on to the issue to demand immediate impeachment proceedings against CEC Gyanesh Kumar in Parliament.

ED files complaint in Chhattisgarh recruitment scam

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Raipur

The Enforcement Directorate (ED)'s Raipur Zonal Office has filed a complaint before the Special PMLA Court in Raipur, taking a major step in one of Chhattisgarh's most closely watched corruption investigations. The complaint under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002, names

Taman Singh Sonwani, former chairman of the Chhattisgarh Public Service Commission; Chetan Borghariya, former Officer on Special Duty in then Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel's Office; Utkarsh Chandrakar; and others as defendants.

The case deals directly with the question of public recruitment. It accuses a well-organised scheme of turning competitive examinations meant to select Deputy Collectors, Deputy Superintendents of

Police, and other senior officers into a market where influence and money could be traded. The ED's investigation stemmed from cases first filed by the State's Economic Offences Wing and Anti-Corruption Bureau over large-scale irregularities in the 2020 and 2021 State Service Examinations.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) eventually took over the underlying offence and prepared the charge sheets. The agency said Utkarsh Chandrakar and his associates obtained more than ₹3 crore in illegal gratification from candidates who took the 2021 examination. The scheme was simple and profitable: it involved releasing the question papers in advance, along with the promise of selection through supposed access to the then Chief Minister's Office.

Candidates were initially



gathered at the Siddhi Vinayak Marriage Palace in Raipur before the preliminary exam, where the leaked paper was handed out. They were then accommodated at the Barnawapara Sanctuary Resort, where coaching for the mains exam went on using the leaked material. Sonwani, who was in charge of the Commission at that time, is alleged to have used his position to bias the process in favour of relatives and other favoured candidates.

Investigators say the recruit-

ment rules were also changed in 2021 by omitting the word "nephew" from the definition of family, allowing selections that would previously have been forbidden. The ED adds that the funds obtained from crime were moved both in cash and through a series of banking channels.

The agency had previously seized movable and immovable property valued at ₹47 lakh belonging to Sonwani, Chandrakar and others as criminal proceeds. The arrests took place in turn: Sonwani on

July 25, 2026, Utkarsh Chandrakar on September 1 and Borghariya on September 11, all under Section 19 of the PMLA. In their investigation, the investigators referred to financial trails that included a number of cash deposits and transactions linking Borghariya's accounts to the alleged network.

The complaint, which extends over dozens of pages and includes thousands of supporting documents, is the ED's first official filing in the area of money laundering.

The submission is a long-overdue move toward accountability for the thousands of genuine aspirants who have prepared for years, only to see selections supposedly determined by money and personal connections. The courts will decide whether the system meant to reward merit can still win back the public's trust.

ED arrests hawala operator in drug case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) arrested Gaurav Dawar, a hawala operator, under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) of 2002. This move is part of an investigation into the large-scale import of heroin, which had been hidden in consignments of semi-processed talc, along with other seizures of narcotics in Delhi, Punjab and Haryana. The next day, Dawar was produced before the Special Judge (PMLA) at the Tis Hazari Courts and was sent back to ED custody for five days.

The investigation into money laundering started when the National Investigation Agency (NIA) filed a First Information Report (FIR) under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act, 1967, the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, 1985, and the Indian Penal Code concerning Harpreet Singh Talwar and others; the NIA has already submitted six charge sheets.

The documents state that a number of the accused conspired with an international drug-smuggling syndicate which was



based in Afghanistan, Pakistan and Dubai. The network is said to have been headed by the wanted accused Vitaysh Koser, also known as Raju Dubai, and to have included agents of the Pakistani ISI and Afghan nationals.

Earlier, investigators with the NIA had quantified the proceeds from the illegal sale of narcotic drugs at about ₹74 crore. The money was passed on via hawala channels to Afghanistan, and it is alleged that it was used to finance terrorist activities.

The ED's follow-up investigation has so far uncovered criminal proceeds amounting to ₹89 crore. This amount includes the proceeds from the smug-

gling of contraband, the distribution of drug proceeds, and funds obtained through hawala operations, such as the ₹74 crore worth of hawala that the NIA has already identified. Officials said they are making further efforts to find additional proceeds generated in the same manner.

The NIA has carried out several search operations under the PMLA in this case, the most recent of which occurred from 15 to 17 July 2026. It has been found that both Gaurav Dawar and co-accused Harpreet Singh Talwar received remuneration both in the form of goods and via hawala for helping to move the drug consign-

ments sent by the overseas syndicate. The payments in the form of goods included banned items such as Gudangaram cigarettes, betel-nut consignments, dry dates and perfumes which Raju Dubai provided. Additionally, Dawar received cash in UAE dirhams directly from Raju Dubai on various occasions when he went to Dubai for the smuggling operations.

The agency stated that the contaminated funds were systematically layered and incorporated into commercial hospitality businesses, nightclubs, and luxury properties. Dawar made cash investments in two nightclubs in Delhi, the Playboy Club and the White Club, operated through Newera Feast and Hospitality Private Limited, along with the co-accused.

The ED has said that the arrest forms part of a comprehensive Government initiative aimed at bringing down the drug-smuggling operation and the related network of money laundering and hawala transactions. The agency has once again stressed its dedication to safeguarding national security and the integrity of India's economic system. Further investigation is still ongoing.

Row over entry passes in MP Youth Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

A dispute over entry passes at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's Chhatron Ki Goonj programme in Indore on September 19 has triggered a war of words within the Madhya Pradesh Youth Congress, with office-bearers questioning the arrangements and the organisation's leadership.

Madhya Pradesh Youth Congress vice-president Sweetie Patil, in a social media post and messages shared in a Youth Congress WhatsApp group, alleged that she had to struggle for hours to obtain an entry pass despite seeking information about the arrangements in advance. She also alleged that workers who had contributed to the organisation were denied passes while others were allowed inside the venue.



Rahul Gandhi addresses Chhatron Ki Goonj event in Indore

Explained: ERONET, ECINet and centralised voter roll dispute

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Every time a person applies to become a voter, seeks a correction in the electoral roll or a change in address, the application eventually makes its way to ERONET, the Election Commission of India (ECI)'s centralised system for managing India's voter database.

ERONET, along with the ECI's newer ECINet platform, has come into focus following a report in The Indian Express that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi raised concerns over centralisation of the electoral roll database and the degree of control available to election officials in States. The two systems are closely linked but are not the same.

ERONET is essentially the back-end electoral roll management system used by

election officials to process applications for registration, migration, correction and deletion of voters. ECINet is a broader platform launched earlier this year to bring more than 40 existing ECI applications and websites, including electoral roll services, under one umbrella.

How does ERONET works?

Until ERONET was introduced, States used different applications and databases to manage their electoral rolls. The ECI says there were 36 separate systems, ranging from spreadsheets to State-specific software. ERONET helped in the creation of a unified database.

The ECI describes it as a "centralised form processing system" for handling voter registration, migration and deletion, among other electoral roll-related processes. But ERONET is not supposed to decide by itself



whether a person gets on or off the voter list.

Under the Representation of the People Act, 1950, the Electoral Registration Officer (ERO) is the statutory authority responsible for preparing and revising the electoral roll of an Assembly constituency. The ECI itself describes ERONET as providing a "decision support

system" to EROs (electoral registration officers).

For instance, if the database detects two entries with similar names, ages and other particulars, it may flag them as possible duplicates. That does not automatically make either entry invalid. The records have to be examined and, where required, field verification carried out

before a decision is taken.

Where does ECINet fit in?

Launched on January 22, 2026, it brings together more than 40 applications and websites that the poll body had built over the years for voters, candidates, political parties and election officials. For voters, these services range from registration and search-

ing electoral rolls to tracking applications, downloading electronic voter identity cards and finding information about polling stations and candidates.

The electoral roll functions earlier handled through ERONET have now been integrated into the ECINet platform. In official documents, the EC now refers to it as the "Electoral Roll module of ECINet Portal (previously ERONET)".

In simple terms, ERONET was built specifically to manage electoral rolls, while ECINet is the larger platform into which those functions and several other election-related services have been integrated.

Why are these systems in the news?

The fact that electoral rolls are managed through a centralised digital system is not new. The questions now being

raised relate to the extent of that centralisation and whether officials who are legally empowered to take decisions on electoral rolls have sufficient control over these systems.

The Indian Express investigation reported that Sandhu and Joshi had raised concerns over what was described as the "gradual centralisation" of the electoral roll database and the access available to election officials in States.

One example cited in the report came from Goa. During the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), EROs heard cases of voters who had been flagged for "logical discrepancies". After examining their cases and documents, the EROs found 97 voters eligible for inclusion in the final electoral roll. However, according to the report, the software did not provide an option to reverse the earlier action and restore

their names. The Goa Chief Electoral Officer's office subsequently sought a "rollback" option from ECI officials.

What are 'logical discrepancies'?

A logical discrepancy is an apparent inconsistency thrown up when voter details are matched with older electoral rolls. It could, for instance, be an age difference between a voter and a parent that appears improbable, or a mismatch between names recorded in old and current electoral rolls. The latter can also arise from transliteration. A name written in a regional language on an old electoral roll may be rendered differently in English when compared with a newer database. Such a flag does not by itself mean the voter is ineligible or that the name will be deleted. It triggers further examination by election officials.

Editor's
TAKE

A campus in mourning, a system on trial

Sahil Wakode's death, whatever its cause, is a verdict on a system that has failed its students and exposes the rot that has claimed three young lives

The death of Sahil Wakode, a second-year B.Tech student in IIT Bombay's Department of Energy Science and Engineering, has shaken India's academic conscience and dominated national headlines. On September 18, hours after he was allegedly caught using a mobile phone during a mid-semester examination-accused of uploading the question paper to an AI platform for answers-Wakode was found dead in his hostel room. No suicide note was recovered. What followed was swifter and murkier: protests erupted across the Powai campus, an FIR was registered under the abetment-to-suicide provision and the SC/ST Act, and within days, Professor Suryanarayana Doolla, who had invigilated the exam, was removed as Dean of Administrative Affairs.

The core dispute is now a contest of narratives. Wakode's parents allege their son endured casteist slurs and "torture" for three months, allegedly at the professor's hands and, they claim, on the director's own instruction. IIT Bombay's administration, led by Director Shireesh Kedare, has firmly denied any caste bias, noting that no complaint was ever filed with the institute's SC/ST cell and insisting Wakode was merely counselled after the exam incident, not threatened with expulsion. His father disputes even the cheating narrative, calling it a deflection from harder questions the institute would rather not answer.

A responsible view must resist collapsing this into a single villain. If the caste allegations hold up, they demand the harshest consequences-for the individuals involved and for an institution now facing this charge twice in three years, since the 2023 death of Darshan Solanki reignited the same debate over caste on IIT campuses. But an FIR is not a conviction, and the administration's denial, however self-serving it may appear, cannot be dismissed until the Mumbai Crime Branch's investigation establishes the facts.

What is not in dispute, and should trouble everyone regardless of which account prevails, is that Wakode is the third student to die by suicide at IIT Bombay in seven months, after Naman Agarwal in February and Sohil Sangwan in July. That statistic alone indicts a campus culture, whatever the specific trigger this time. As things stand, Doolla has been removed from his administrative post, though not yet formally charged pending inquiry, while Kedare remains director despite student demands for his resignation. Protesting students have raised eighteen demands, chief among them an independent investigation panel-with external and student representation-expected to report by September 30, alongside a serious overhaul of the mental health and counselling infrastructure on campus.

The way forward cannot be cosmetic. IIT Bombay needs a genuinely independent probe insulated from institutional self-interest, a functioning and trusted SC/ST grievance mechanism that students actually believe in, and examination-malpractice protocols that counsel rather than terrorise students already buckling under academic pressure.



How Modi changed Odisha's growth story

In Odisha, Modi's impact is increasingly visible — in roads and railways, ports and airports, investment and tribal development. The larger question is whether this Centre-State partnership is doing more than building infrastructure: is it reshaping Odisha's place in India's economic landscape?



MOHAN
CHARAN
MAJHI

On September 17, Prime Minister Narendra Modi turned 76. Birthdays like this usually bring out tributes. I could write one easily enough. But I'd rather ask a simpler question. It's the kind of question a state government owes its own people. Has this leadership actually changed how Odisha grows? I think it has. I want to walk you through 'why' and 'how'.

This question isn't abstract for me. For Odisha, a state long rich in mineral wealth but historically kept on the edge of national economic planning, the answer isn't just rhetorical but measurable. You can see it in rail connectivity, in port capacity and in investment inflows. A policy architecture called Purvodaya now treats eastern India's growth as central and not something of secondary importance.

From welfare list to growth strategy

The Prime Minister's idea of Sabka Saath Sabka Vikas gets talked about mostly in political terms. The more useful test for me is administrative. Has it actually changed how we get access to the state? In Odisha's case, it has. Our tribal communities make up 23 per cent of the state's population. They used to be treated mainly as a welfare category. Now they sit at the centre of how we plan industry and infrastructure, including value addition in the mineral belt and coverage under Ayushman Bharat and PM Awas Yojana.

The point I want to make here is structural, not personal. When a government treats tribal-belt development as a core economic strategy rather than a mere side welfare programme, outcomes change at scale. That shift will possibly outlast me and every other Chief Minister.

What has the double-engine government built?

Since our government took office, closer coordination between Bhubaneswar and Delhi has produced things we can actually track. A rail programme built to connect all 30 districts of the state. Continued expansion of capacity at Paradip Port. There is a massive effort to build new roads, ports and airports. We are building connectivity across land, water and air. A real and sustained push to bring in global capital.

That last point isn't theory for me right now. I got back from a three-day investment roadshow in the UAE, and our delegation across Abu Dhabi and Dubai proudly came away with proposals worth roughly ₹2.43 lakh crore. The potential is well close to nine lakh jobs, along



with eight signed MoUs. The total investment proposals with us now are over ₹22.5 lakh crore. We are already witnessing investments worth over ₹3.11 lakh crore on the ground. Factories are being built, production being commissioned and jobs being created.

I must proudly say that Odisha can now walk into a room with sovereign wealth funds and be taken seriously. Not as a place you extract minerals from but as an investment destination in its own right. That is the change I keep trying to describe.

That is what Purvodaya actually means in practice. It isn't a slogan about eastern India rising. But it's about infrastructure spending and investor attention finally going to a region that spent decades exporting raw minerals and getting very little value addition back.

Our own state initiatives add to that, which is a reduced stamp duty for economically weaker sections under PMAY-U 2.0, along with new irrigation and water security projects. All of it is meant to keep that investment local, not let it pass through.

Security first

Growth needs peace before it can take root. Odisha's security situation has genuinely changed. Districts that were Maoist strongholds for three decades, places like Malkangiri, Koraput and Kandhamal, have seen a real and sustained fall in Naxal activity. Growth corridors and security corridors have finally lined up. That didn't happen consistently in earlier decades. I count it as one of the quieter but more important results of Centre-State coordination under this government.

Closing the gap

Odisha's per capita income and human development indicators still trail several peer states. We are working to close them, not explain them away. One such instance is our Subhadra Yojana. This is one attempt to close income gaps for women. The scheme, along with the rest of the Purvodaya effort, is actually delivering measurable effects. The reports of several organisations, like IIM Sambalpur and SBI, are encouraging. Women are increasingly attracted to doing business.

Confident abroad, close to home

In the end, what strikes me most about the Prime Minister's decade in office isn't any one particular scheme. It's the way he holds two things together that rarely sit comfortably in Indian politics. First, a foreign policy that is confident enough to negotiate as an equal at G20 forums. Second, a domestic style, Mann Ki Baat above all, built around direct connect with people in India's smallest villages.

Odisha's international profile used to be thin despite our coastline and our mineral wealth. That global confidence has had a real spillover effect now. International capital is now willing to look at eastern India for investments, and not just as a development liability.

With Modi at the helm, we are confident of Odisha's transformation in a few more years. Odisha is narrowing the gap. The coming years are going to be our years of destiny. Samruddha Odisha is in the offing.

The writer is the
Chief Minister of Odisha

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Squirrel's Share of the Bridge

We tend to believe our contribution only counts if it is large enough to be noticed. The building of the bridge to Lanka quietly corrects that belief.

As Rama's army of monkeys and bears carried massive boulders to build a bridge across the ocean, a small squirrel began rolling in the sand and shaking pebbles from its fur onto the rocks, trying to help in whatever way it could.

Some mocked its tiny effort as meaningless beside such enormous labour. Rama, noticing this, stopped, picked up the squirrel gently, and stroked its back, declaring that its contribution mattered exactly as much as any boulder carried by the mightiest warrior.

Scale was never the measure. Sincerity of effort was.

We often hold back from helping because our contribution feels too small to matter beside what others bring, forgetting that effort is not measured by size, but by whole-heartedness.

Today, offer whatever small effort is within your reach toward something meaningful, without waiting until you can contribute something larger.

—DAIV

The power of changing our perspective



RAJYOGI
BRAHMA
KUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

It's a common thing for us to experience emotions directly through the body. For example, when we go out to meet someone whom we love a lot, we walk lightly with our hearts pounding with excitement, whereas anxiety might tighten our muscles and make our hands sweat and tremble before an important job interview, right? Numerous studies carried out over the last decade or so have established that emotion systems prepare us to meet challenges encountered in the environment by adjusting the activation of the cardiovascular, skeletomuscular, neuroendocrine and autonomic nervous systems.

This link between emotions and bodily states is also reflected in the way we speak or behave. For example, a young girl who is about to get married in a week's time may suddenly have cold feet and experience nervousness.



Similarly, those lovers who have had a bad break-up and are heartbroken may experience a shiver down their spine on hearing their favourite song being played somewhere. To put it in simple words, all the above examples mean that our thoughts and feelings can affect our body directly, and they can very well have an effect on what we think, what we feel and what we do.

Shakespeare rightly said, "For there is nothing either good or bad, but thinking makes it so." The fact is that even though we are not faced with sabre-toothed tigers every day, life presents us with lots of situations which can be perceived as threatening, naturally triggering a stress response from within us. For example, if you climb the stairs instead of taking a lift to your fourth-floor apartment and, immediately after entering your home, you experience uncomfortable symptoms like a pounding heart and excessive sweat-

ing, you might instantly have the thought: "Gosh, I'm not as fit as I used to be; maybe I need to see my doctor and get a thorough check-up."

Now suppose that instead of having a negative thought on entering home, you just sit down calmly and do a simple deep-breathing exercise. You may feel completely fine in a few minutes and continue with your day as usual, without any great change in how you feel. This example clearly shows that the same experience, if interpreted differently, can result in very different feelings and emotions.

Today, most of us are living in body consciousness resulting from the false identification of the self with the body. Such limited identities then influence our thoughts and actions and give rise to emotions like insecurity, fear, selfishness and hatred. Thus, those who are ignorant of the soul are severely bound by their body, and they think, act and live their whole lives in a narrow, limited way that makes everything in their lives limited.

Hence, in order to live a liberated life, we need to realise the truth that we are all spiritual beings in a human body and, birth after birth, we continue to play different roles. Thus, by being soul-conscious, we can transcend our fears, attachments and vices, and we can also conquer the fear of death and any kind of physical loss, thereby experiencing our original qualities such as peace, joy and love in an unlimited way.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

SIR and the irony of democracy

A telemarketer once called then Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee to offer him a housing loan during a meeting with the Opposition. Bureaucracy and reality collided to produce unintended comedy.

SIR has discovered its own humour. During the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, names such as LK Advani, S Jaishankar, Jagdeep Dhankhar, Rekha Gupta, Arvind Kejriwal and SS Sandhu have figured among those receiving notices over electoral discrepancies. The Election Commission clarified that receiving a notice does not, by itself, mean deletion from the electoral roll. It is part of a verification process and gives the person concerned an opportunity to establish the details.

But if people who have occupied high public offices can find themselves having to produce documents to establish their electoral credentials, what does this mean for an ordinary citizen with limited paperwork, an outdated address, missing records or little familiarity with official procedures?

The right to vote is universal. Its exercise should not become a bureaucratic obstacle course. Democracy gives every citizen one vote. SIR, it seems, may first demand a file to prove that you exist.

AP THIRUVAD | CHENNAI

Erdogan raises Kashmir issue at UNGA

Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan has raised the Kashmir issue again at the United Nations General Assembly, calling for disputes in South Asia to be addressed through dialogue and within the framework of the UN Charter. "In South Asia, it is important that all disputes, including the Kashmir issue, be addressed through dialogue within the framework of the United Nations Charter and relevant resolutions," Erdogan said in his address on Tuesday.

He delivered the remarks in the presence of Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif at the UN headquarters. Erdogan has repeatedly used the UNGA platform to raise the Kashmir issue in recent years, despite India's objections. Beyond Kashmir, Erdogan used his address to call for stronger international action on Gaza, renewed recognition of Palestinian statehood and reforms to the UN Security Council.

Erdogan has used his UNGA addresses to comment on Kashmir on several occasions. His remarks have varied in tone, but the issue has remained a recurring feature of his speeches.

The remarks drew attention to Ankara's focus on Kashmir at the UNGA, while India has opposed references to Kashmir.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Celebrating the girl child

National Daughters' Day, celebrated on September 25, is an occasion to celebrate and cherish the girl child and remind daughters how deeply they are loved and valued. Although children need no special occasion to receive love and affection, the day gives parents an opportunity to express appreciation and create special memories with their daughters.

A daughter is a precious gift to a family. She brings love, warmth and happiness into the home and can grow into a strong pillar of support. In Indian culture, daughters are often regarded as a blessing and lovingly associated with Lakshmi, the Hindu goddess of wealth and prosperity. Daughters' Day also highlights the importance of girls in society and reinforces the message that girls are equal to boys and deserve the same opportunities to learn, grow and succeed. It provides an opportunity to challenge social prejudices that have, in some communities, treated the birth of a girl as less desirable than that of a boy.

Parents play a vital role in building a daughter's confidence by encouraging her abilities, supporting her dreams and respecting her individuality.

Every girl deserves love, education, dignity, encouragement and equal opportunities.

JUBEL D'CRUZ | MUMBAI

PICTALK



Students form a human chain in the shape of India's map as part of the 'Seva Sankalp Abhiyan', in Prayagraj

PHOTO: PTI

Minor forest produce: Reconciling forest rights with conservation

The system governing minor forest produce collection and trade is caught between overlapping laws, unclear institutional responsibilities, weak regulation and growing commercial pressure. Unless forest rights are balanced with ecological responsibility, India risks degrading the very resource on which millions of forest communities depend



India has traditionally maintained a powerful presence in global natural ingredient supply chains, exporting processed lac, natural gums and herbal extracts to international pharmaceutical, food and cosmetic markets. India's trade in Non-Timber Forest Produce (Minor Forest Produce, or MFP, in legal parlance) and bio-based commodities reveals two distinct structural dynamics: agricultural/cultivated natural commodities, such as guar gum and herbal extracts, maintain large export volumes, whereas commodities of wild origin harvested from forests, such as tendu leaves, myrobalans, khair and tree gums, are trapped in stagnant or declining domestic yields and business.

Over the recent five-year period, natural medicinal extracts generated ₹4,500 crore to ₹6,500 crore annually due to expanding global demand for nutraceuticals and phytoconstituents. Guar gum and resins yielded around ₹3,300 crore to ₹5,200 crore, while processed lac gave export earnings of ₹280 crore to ₹400 crore per year. Conversely, traditional wild/forest-origin commodities faced severe structural decline: tendu leaves, earning under ₹160 crore, followed a downward trajectory, while the value of myrobalans exported was ₹40 crore to ₹80 crore and that of khair (katha/cutch) under ₹40 crore.

Driven by expanding global demand and the value of natural products, monetary values may sometimes appear to climb, but in the heart of India's ancient woodlands, a silent legal, economic and ecological tragedy is brewing. While global procurement standards strictly mandate product traceability, organic certification and consistent quality, India's forest produce trade is plunging into chaos due to unorganised and fragmented extraction of MFPs under a puzzling criss-cross of legal instruments, poor implementation of laws and weak local management, habitat depletion-led unsustainability in yields, adulteration and poor post-harvest handling, with a lack of functional primary processing units. In fact, the sustainability of MFPs, ranging from gums and bamboos to lac, resins and medicinal plants, which forms the economic backbone for over 100 million forest-dependent individuals across the country, is under threat.

A serious danger to India's minor forest produce (MFP) stems from a chaotic clash and, quite often, an executive misinterpretation of overlapping statutes - including the Panchayat (Extension to Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996 (PESA); the Scheduled Tribes and Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition of Forest Rights) Act, 2006 (FRA); the Biological Diversity Act, 2002; and amendments to the Indian Forest Act, 1927, along with the decriminalisation of some forest and forest-land-related offences by the Jan Vishwas Act, 2023. They collectively result in a de facto severance of economic extraction rights from ecological responsibility on the ground. Although PESA uses the phrase 'Gram Sabhas are endowed with the ownership of Minor Forest Produce', the prevalent perception of people's relationship with MFP does not go beyond viewing selected MFPs as money-yielding resources simply to be exploited for financial gain. The overstretching of the term 'ownership' used in PESA and FRA to include 'management' as well as ownership of unsevered, standing minor forest produce (which is essentially an immovable property belonging to the state), coupled with the non-formalisation of the duties of FRA beneficiaries, local-level institutions (such as Joint Forest Management committees) and Gram Sabhas, although mandated by the FRA, has been disastrous. The poorly integrated Biological Diversity Act's access and benefit-sharing (ABS) mechanism, for want of a clearly determined chain of custody, has affected the erstwhile unified oversight, leaving regulatory boundaries blurred.

Non-realisation of the dangers of sidelining experienced Forest Department to leave today's unequipped and overburdened Gram Sabhas in sole charge of complex forest ecosystems is dreadful. Any unregulated commercial extraction through management plans destroys natural regeneration, severely compromises critical ecosystem services and collapses tribal livelihood safety nets. The



AS REGARDS GOVERNANCE, THE COMMERCIAL MOVEMENT OF MINOR FOREST PRODUCE REQUIRES ROBUST DIGITAL TRACEABILITY AND TRANSIT CONTROLS, SUCH AS INTEGRATION WITH THE NATIONAL TRANSIT PASS SYSTEM (NTPS) TIED TO HARVEST DECLARATIONS. GEOTAGGING OF HARVEST ORIGINS MUST BE INSISTED UPON TO PREVENT ILLEGAL REMOVALS AND CURB THE LAUNDERING OF ILLICIT FOREST PRODUCE UNDER THE PRETEXT OF EXERCISING FOREST RIGHTS

BKP Sinha and Arvind Kumar Jha are Former Principal Chief Conservators of Forests (PCCFs), Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra

conundrum is compounded by the 2023 Community Forest Rights guidelines issued by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs, local-level attempts to edge out the enforcement machinery in the name of democratisation, and institutional abdication exhibited by the forestry sector.

The ground-level situation created due to the above leaves the Gram Sabhas vulnerable to capture by commercial trade syndicates. The examples of the working of bamboo and tendu leaves in states such as Maharashtra are worth studying in this regard. On the silvicultural front, abandonment of scientific working plans and carrying-capacity limits, combined with market forces, is directly leading to destructive tapping, ring-barking and over-harvesting, destroying the natural regeneration of species such as bamboo, khair, tendu and gum karaya. Driven by powerful global and domestic market forces demanding cheap raw botanicals, the institutional vacuum provides easy ground for commercial intermediaries to maximise short-term profits, threatening the irreversible ecological collapse of forest canopies and the ultimate destruction of the very resource on which tribal livelihoods depend.

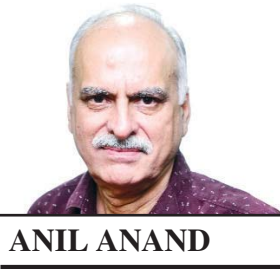
A prominent concern is the selective projection of isolated success stories driven by exceptional civil society support or rare administrative leadership. Such examples can mask the gap between statutory intent and ground implementation elsewhere. As a result, scalability suffers, site-specific needs remain unaddressed, and many tribal and forest-dweller communities remain disempowered. Protecting ecological capital while respecting forest dwellers' rights requires an urgent course correction.

Sustaining forest rights to MFPs while ensuring ecological sustainability requires a clear statutory distinction between ownership of harvested produce and responsibility for overall forest management. The Forest Department must maintain forest health and sustained MFP supply through scientific working plans, while rights holders must respect carrying-capacity limits. This balance should involve Joint Forest Management committees on public forest lands. In 'Community Forest Resource' areas, formal management plans should be implemented within the statutory framework of the FRA, as mandated.

As regards governance, commercial movement of minor forest produce requires robust digital traceability and transit controls, including integration with the National Transit Pass System (NTPS) and harvest declarations. Geo-tagging harvest origins can prevent illegal removals and curb laundering of illicit forest produce. State procurement bodies such as TRIFED, the Girijan Cooperative Corporation and state MFP federations should move from passive buyers to active stewardship partners, linking Minimum Support Price disbursements to sustainably harvested and certified MFPs while supporting biodiversity conservation and natural regeneration. At the village level, institutional mechanisms should be rationalised, with tribal self-help group hubs for primary processing and capacity-building to ensure greater local economic benefits.

Finally, the escalation of pressure on forest resources, gradual reduction in MFP production and expansion of local stakeholder populations make it imperative to enact policy decisions that reduce reliance on minor forest produce of wild origin. As a concomitant measure, national policy must shift towards promoting high-value species cultivation on private farmlands while simultaneously strengthening protection measures in forest areas to curb illicit removals. Focus should be given to skill training in ecotourism and green technologies that move local youth into higher-paying, off-forest jobs. Simultaneously, systems for rewarding conservation, utilisation of carbon markets and creating allied livelihoods with predictable incomes must be established to make, especially for forest dwellers, our living forests far more valuable than harvested MFPs. It's high time the policymakers took a call on this!

Tamil Nadu alliance vs INDIA Bloc



The few months that Vijay has been in power in Tamil Nadu after dislodging the powerful ruling DMK have portrayed a new-era politician with a fresh outlook and unconventional ways of pursuing politics. Even in governance, though it is a very short span to form a view of his style of functioning, he has been exhibiting the courage to abandon the beaten tracks of traditional politics and harp on a new path to strike a better rapport with the public, particularly Gen Z, in line with his image as a young superstar turned political leader.

The formation of the new alliance has to be viewed against this backdrop. The fact that Congress, now sharing power in Tamil Nadu after six decades, has agreed to become part of it without any commitment or clear stand by Vijay on whether or not to join the I.N.D.I.A. bloc at the national level makes it both interesting and complicated.

Did Congress leader Rahul Gandhi jump the gun by abandoning the DMK before the recently held Assembly elections and joining Vijay's bandwagon? Electorally, his judgement was not wrong, as TVK strode to an impressive victory, with Congress piggybacking to ultimately share power as part of what is known as the SSJVA. Prior to that, he had inclined towards fighting the 2024 Lok Sabha elections in alliance with TVK and not the DMK. But Gandhi's proposal was scuttled by his own party leaders from Tamil Nadu, led by former Union Minister and now Rajya Sabha MP P Chidambaram.

Perhaps, Gandhi had rightly understood the prevailing ground realities in the state, where Congress had been pushed to the margins by the Dravidian parties, which did not give the Grand Old Party (GOP) an inch on the Tamil Nadu turf. This was despite the DMK, a regional party, becoming a dominant partner in the Congress-led UPA governments and becoming the biggest beneficiary. The DMK chief, M K Stalin, had rejected the Congress demand, before the Assembly election, for a pre-poll understanding to share power with the GOP in case the alliance retained power. On the contrary, Vijay gladly accepted Congress as a partner in the government.

Although the DMK, after its defeat in the Assembly elections and Congress deciding to side with TVK, immediately severed its relations with the I.N.D.I.A. bloc, it is still to chalk out a clear line of alignment at the national level. Will it go with the BJP-led NDA, stay neutral, or maintain a strategic connect with the Congress-led opposition parties' alliance? Stalin has still to clear the mist despite sending mixed signals to keep the DMK's political significance intact even at the national level. The most contentious issue preventing the DMK from joining the Narendra Modi-led NDA is the delimitation of constituencies and the consequential increase in the number of Lok Sabha seats. Under the scheme of things as planned by the BJP regime, the southern states stand to lose out to the cow-belt states, which are strongholds of the BJP, as it will further strengthen the saffron party's grip on its traditional citadels.

That is where Stalin is stuck and unable to take a final call, though he is said to be negotiating with Modi and his team to extract a clear-cut assurance on delimitation being carried out in such a manner as not to harm the interests of the southern states. An indication towards this wait-and-watch game is seen in the Government not proroguing the Monsoon Session of Parliament even after nearly a month, to keep the window open for reconvening the same session in the hope that it arrives at an understanding with the ilk of Stalin and other political parties having reservations about the delimitation move.

There is a strong school of thought that believes that Gandhi should not have severed relations with the DMK, given the party's strength in the Lok Sabha, by which it can help Modi sail through Parliament, ensuring the passage of crucial and contentious Bills such as those related to delimitation of constituencies and the Women's Reservation Bill. No one knows the Congress strategy relating to this aspect and whether Gandhi has kept his personal channels open with Stalin, with whom he enjoyed good relations while being coalition partners.

It would be naïve to think that Congress would not have taken into account the significance of the DMK's strength in the two Houses of Parliament, given the fact that the ruling NDA, with the BJP, is heavily dependent on alliance partners and outside support. If not so, the GOP should be ready to take the blame if the DMK decides to support the crucial Bills being piloted by the Government.

A vital question arising out of the new Tamil Nadu-centric alliance is: how will it impact the INDIA. bloc and, in turn, national politics from the point of view of an anti-BJP alliance, particularly with an eye on the 2029 Lok Sabha elections? Will the SSJVA act as a counterforce and weaken the existing opposition combine at the national level? The three main characters in this act are keeping their cards close to their chests. This has resulted in speculation gaining currency as to the future shape of things on opposition unity. Gandhi's silence, Stalin's Machiavellian reticence and Vijay's shrewd demeanour have made the act look complicated. In this game of political articulation, both Stalin and Vijay seem to be better and comfortably placed. This is because neither of them has a direct interest at the national level, whereas Gandhi (read Congress), being the premier opposition party, is the main rival to Modi and, for that, the pivot of the opposition unity. So, the stakes are greater.



The writer is a policy analyst

India in the emerging multipolar world order



The architecture of global power that took shape after the Cold War no longer holds. Nations are regrouping and realigning under the pressure of geopolitical upheaval and domestic imperatives, while technology is rewriting the very meaning of sovereignty and economic interdependence buckles under new strategic rivalries. As the world's largest democracy, India's choices now carry weight far beyond its borders — shaping international security, trade, technology governance, climate action and the development priorities of the Global South. Its simultaneous engagement with the G20, BRICS, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the QUAD, alongside bilateral partnerships spanning divergent geopolitical camps, is the clearest expression of this multi-aligned approach.

The institutions built to manage global affairs no longer mirror today's distribution of power. The UN Security Council needs reform, and the Global South deserves a stronger voice in international financial and trade bodies. India's push for a permanent seat should be framed not merely as a claim to status commensurate with its growth trajectory, but as part of a broader effort to ensure Asia, Africa, Latin America and the wider devel-

oping world are properly represented in institutions whose decisions shape peace, finance, trade, technology and sustainable development.

That role as a rule-shaper extends into climate diplomacy. India's position rests on common but differentiated responsibility — climate justice demands real climate finance, technology transfer and resilient infrastructure, not just ambitious pledges, particularly for communities most exposed to environmental change. Development that hollows out its own ecological base cannot last, and environmental policy that ignores jobs, poverty and energy access will not hold public trust either. The task is to fuse economic progress with environmental and social responsibility, not treat them as competing goals.

In an emerging multipolar order, India is positioning itself as one of its central poles, drawing on capability, relationships and geography rather than choosing sides. Its foreign policy can no longer be framed as East versus West; it must engage East, West, North and South at once, without surrendering strategic autonomy. That requires diplomacy supple enough to bend with circumstance — recalling Henry Kissinger's observation that nuance, flexibility and occasional ambiguity are the tools of the trade.

Technology has become one of the sharpest instruments of geopolitical power. Artificial intelligence, semiconductors, quantum computing, telecommunications, satellites, digital platforms



and cross-border data flows now shape a nation's economic, strategic and military weight — and whoever controls critical technology and data infrastructure will command disproportionate influence over the coming order. India's Digital Public Infrastructure — its identity, payments and public-service systems — has already shown what this can look like at scale, drawing global attention. But modern economies run on interconnected digital networks for banking, energy, transport, healthcare and governance, which makes them vulnerable: a single cyberattack on critical infrastructure can cause disruption no army could match, demanding constantly evolving cyber defences. Data, meanwhile, is both an economic asset and a matter of identity and privacy, and reconciling innovation with security and individual rights is arguably the hardest of these challenges - with artificial intelligence posing the most complex test of all.

Trade and economic resilience are now inseparable from national security.

Recent global shocks exposed how dangerous it is to depend on narrow sources for energy, medicines, semiconductors, critical minerals and defence equipment, pushing economic diplomacy from a supporting role into a central strategic instrument. India's exports are already feeling the strain of US sanctions, sharpened by the Sanctioning of Russia and Iran Act of 2026, which hands President Trump discretionary power to penalise not just any country - India and China included — buying Russian energy. Yet confident, steady leadership can weather such headwinds: India remains the world's largest sovereign democratic republic, on course to become its third-largest economy, and no external pressure can indefinitely check that trajectory.

A stronger global voice also demands an impenetrable shield of national security - secure borders, freedom from infiltration and the capacity to respond decisively to emerging threats. That no longer means conventional military readiness alone; nations now face cross-border terrorism, cyberattacks, organised transnational crime, information warfare, economic coercion, infrastructure attacks and threats from space, all under the umbrella of hybrid warfare that no single armed force can handle alone. It demands tighter coordination among security agencies, technology institutions, financial regulators and civil society, rather than leaving the burden to the

armed forces alone, while space itself - vital to communications, navigation, weather forecasting, banking, disaster response and defence — becomes a domain India must actively protect through responsible conduct and hardened assets. As Kautilya wrote two millennia ago, the treasury is the foundation of the army, and the army the instrument that protects the state; economic strength remains the bedrock of both security and strategic autonomy, and no nation sustains the latter without the former.

India's ambition to become a developed nation by 2047 depends on growth that is not just high but fair — avoiding a K-shaped economy that widens disparities and breeds discontent. Spending on education, health, research and defence should be read as investment in national capability, not expenditure, since economic development, technology, human capital and security reinforce one another.

Ultimately, India cannot shape global rules without economic and technological strength, and it cannot sustain that strength without secure borders, resilient supply chains, energy security and dependable partnerships. Its influence will be measured not by GDP, military size or seats at the table, but by the principles it upholds, the trust it earns and the solutions it delivers to a fracturing world.

The writer is former Additional Secretary, Lok Sabha, and a Member of the Supreme Court Bar Association. The article is an abridged version of the keynote address delivered by him at the National Seminar held by Amity Law School, Noida



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Order Order

Cinematographic film not IT software under GST: HC

A cinematographic film is not IT software under the GST law, even if delivered via a digital link or hard disk, the Bombay High Court has held while setting aside a tax demand of over ₹79.7 crore from Karan Johar's two production companies. The mode of delivery remains irrelevant to tax classification, a Bench of Justices M S Karnik and Sandesh Patil held in the judgment passed on September 10 in a plea filed by Johar's Dharma Productions and Dharmatic Entertainment. There is nothing on record to show how a cinematographic film, a passive audio-visual work, incapable of execution, manipulation or interactivity could ever satisfy the statutory definition of "information technology software", it said. Whether the content is transmitted physically (hard disks) or electronically, the mode of delivery cannot determine classification, the HC said, adding that there was no statutory basis to equate digital content with software. The dispute concerned the classification of copyright licensing of films. Tax authorities treated the transactions as licensing of IT software under Services Accounting Code (SAC) 998340, attracting 18 per cent Goods and Services Tax (GST). The state tax department had raised a tax demand of ₹79.7 crore for the period between the financial years 2017-18 and 2020-21, claiming that delivering film content through digital links or hard disks brought the transaction under IT software services. Dharma Productions and Dharmatic Entertainment then filed a plea in the HC to challenge the demand, arguing that they were licensing intellectual property rights in cinematographic films under SAC 997332, which attracted 12 per cent GST during the relevant period.



Private WhatsApp messages not public criticism: HP HC

The Himachal Pradesh High Court has ordered the reinstatement of a contract-based conductor of the HRTC, holding that a private conversation on WhatsApp cannot be treated as public criticism and that employees have a right to air their grievances and vent their frustration. The court quashed Himachal Road Transport Corporation's (HRTC) October 10, 2023 order terminating the services of conductor Sunil Kumar, who was appointed on a contract basis in 2021. In September 2023, some conductors created a WhatsApp group named "Himachal Parichalal Ekt", in which Kumar shared two general messages discussing a review of the corporation's new rules and their possible advantages and disadvantages for employees. HRTC management treated the messages as a violation of its social media guidelines and the terms of Kumar's contract and terminated his services in October 2023. He subsequently approached the High Court challenging the decision. During the hearing, the court observed that it was natural for employees of any organisation to have grievances against the management. "In the interest of the organisation itself, it is better to allow such grievances to be expressed, as this can have a corrective effect. Unless such expression directly harms the organisation's reputation, the management should not interfere," the court said. The court also found that HRTC had already formed the opinion that Kumar was unfit to continue in service at the stage of issuing the show-cause notice itself.



Delhi HC grants bail to ex-ADAG executive Amitabh Jhunjunwala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has granted bail to Amitabh Jhunjunwala, a former senior executive of the Anil Dhirubhai Ambani Group (ADAG), in an alleged bank loan fraud-linked money laundering case. Justice Madhu Jain said the health condition of the 70-year-old accused required a "structured and continuing medical care", making him entitled to the benefit of the statutory exception for grant of bail for "sick or infirm" under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. The judge said the material before the court disclosed a "combination of advanced age, significant spinal pathology, osteoporosis, the requirement of supervised rehabili-



tation, and a pre-existing cardiac condition requiring continued management." Jhunjunwala, arrested on April 15 by the Enforcement Directorate, sought regular bail on medical grounds in the case. He will, however, continue to remain in custody in a case being probed by the CBI, in which he was arrested on June 1. The ED opposed the plea, saying the petitioner did not meet the threshold of being "sick" or "infirm".

CJI urged to consider permanent Constitution bench

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Flagging the inordinate delay in resolution of references made to larger Benches, the Supreme Court on Wednesday termed it a "source of institutional embarrassment" and requested the Chief Justice of India to explore the necessity of setting up a permanent five-judge Constitution bench. A Bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma termed the delay as an area of "grave concern" and said self-introspection was required as pendency of reference for far too long does not reflect well on the institution. The observations were made after both the judges gave split opinions on whether a batch of pleas challenging the validity of a 2023 law that excludes the CJI from the panel for selecting the Chief Election Commissioner and Election Commissioners should be



referred to a larger Bench. The bench said if statistics are any guide, none can say with any reasonable degree of certainty when long-pending references will get resolved. "Undisputedly, this is an area of grave concern and the inordinate delay in resolution of the references is itself a source of institutional embarrassment which all stakeholders ought to strive to avoid. Self-introspection, indeed, is required," it said. "We, thus, take this opportunity of requesting the Chief Justice of India to also explore the necessity of constituting a permanent five-judge Bench to decide pure constitutional issues," the Bench said. It said this is not something novel that the bench is saying. "It has been opined time and again by responsible citizens of the country and we simply endorse their opinion," it said. The bench said, "Given that resolving constitutional issues is the primary task of judges of this court, that must

remain its core priority." It said pendency of references for far too long, any period between five and 20 years or more, does not reflect well on the institution. "It is time that the institution addresses the issue with the urgency and promptitude it deserves," it said. The bench said it need to notice a concern expressed by the petitioners not on the merits but on the time taken by the top court to decide references. Both the judges said they were part of a nine-judge constitution bench, which had recently delivered its verdict on the contentious issue of defining the term "industry" under the Industrial Disputes Act, 1947. "It took nine years for the reference made by the seven-judge Bench to travel to the nine-judge bench and five months more for the Bench to decide," the Bench said. It said prior to that, the reference in the matter

remained pending for 15 years since 2002. "The petitioners seem to be justified in expressing their anxiety that references to five-judge Benches remain unresolved for years together," it said. The Bench also referred to a March 2, 2023 verdict delivered by a five-judge constitution Bench. In that landmark verdict aimed at insulating the appointment of the CEC and ECs from the executive's interference, the five-judge Bench had ruled that their appointments will be made by the president on the advice of a committee comprising the prime minister, the Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha and the CJI. On Wednesday, the Bench said the decision in that case arose out of a writ petition filed in 2015. It said in that matter, reference to a constitution bench was made in 2018 and it took another five years for the Bench to give its decision

and dispose of the petition. While dealing with the pleas challenging the validity of the 2023 law that excludes the CJI from the panel for selecting the CEC and ECs, Justice Datta refused to accept the Centre's submission that the petitions raise questions of constitutional importance and should be referred to a five-judge constitution bench. Justice Sharma, however, disagreed with the views of Justice Datta. The Bench said the matter be placed before the CJI for considering the desirability of constituting a Constitution bench to decide the matter. "The issues that would engage the consideration of the five-judge Bench being of foundational importance to the democratic fabric of the country and its citizenry, we earnestly hope and trust that this reference would not suffer the inordinate delay in its resolution as in other cases," the Bench said.

Duty-free shops bound by Indian law: Bombay High Court upholds ban on nicotine pouches

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Duty-free shops are not exempt from domestic regulatory laws, the Bombay High Court has held, refusing to interfere with the ban on sale of imported nicotine pouches by such outlets at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport. In a judgment passed on Tuesday, a bench of Justices Suman Shyam and Advait Sethna said import of goods into India, even if for the limited purpose of warehousing or re-export, would not enjoy any immunity from the application of the domestic laws. The order was passed on a petition filed by Mumbai Travel Retail Limited and Flemingo Dutyfree Shop Private Limited, challenging the ban imposed by the



Drugs Controller General on the sale of their imported nicotine pouches under the brand names 'Zyn' and 'Fox'. The authorities have banned the sale of the product over want of licences issued under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act. "Such goods would be subject to the law of the land and would be governed by the regulatory regime in force even if the transaction takes place in the duty free shops, beyond the customs barrier," HC said. If an item is restricted or prohibited under any law currently in force, it would be considered "prohibited goods". The domestic regulatory regime will apply in full force to such goods brought into the duty-free shops within Indian territorial jurisdiction, the court said. The bench, however,

refrained from deciding whether tobacco-free nicotine pouches are 'drugs' under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act and directed the issue to be decided by the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation. On April 2, the authorities banned the sale of imported tobacco-free nicotine pouches at the city's international airport, classifying them as 'drugs' under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, thus making registration certificates and import licences mandatory. However, the petitioners claimed that the domestic regulatory regime would not apply to the sale of nicotine pouches, as they are meant only for consumption by the outbound travellers in the International Departure Terminal.

Bombay HC bans firecrackers on road during festivals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court, while banning the bursting of firecrackers on roads during festivals, has criticised the Maharashtra government for painting a rosy picture and chanting the 'All is Well' mantra, noting that rules on noise pollution were not being implemented. The HC stressed the need for "total restraint" on loud music and called for a more dignified and civilised way of celebrating festivals. There was a "total laxity" on the part of the enforcement machinery in implementing the Noise Pollution (Regulation and Control) Rules, a bench of Justices Girish Kulkarni and Neela Gokhale held on Tuesday. It ordered a complete ban on loudspeakers, DJs, laser



beams and bursting of firecrackers on public roads during festival processions. The court had taken suo motu (on its own) cognisance of the issue of severe noise and air pollution caused during processions. Such things were completely unwarranted and festivals can be celebrated without causing noise and air pollution, it remarked, while noting that a more dignified and civilised way of having these processions and celebrations was the imminent requirement of the contemporary times. "Are we going to get additional blessings from God by using all these loudspeakers and firecrackers? As a responsible society, we should put an end to all this. Take the Wari procession (annual pilgrimage on foot to Pandharpur) for example. It is carried out so peacefully with absolutely no loudspeakers or noise," the HC noted. In its order made

available on Wednesday, the court said it cannot accept the state government's attempt of "painting a rosy picture and reciting the mantra of 'All is well'." "We do not agree, looking at the ground realities which have at all relevant times in the past been a matter of serious concern in successive proceedings, and there is no change in such reality of brazen violations on this count," the HC said. Permissions granted by the police for such processions and other general orders banning the use of firecrackers, loudspeakers, laser beams and DJs in the night remain a routine formality and are rendered ineffective by the inaction of the official machinery, thus permitting every kind of violation, it noted.

Bail granted to 6 Ukrainians in Myanmar drone case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Wednesday granted default bail to six Ukrainian nationals, arrested in connection with a case being probed by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) involving a drone-warfare training camp linked to ethnic armed groups in Myanmar. Special NIA Judge Prashant Sharma granted bail to the six Ukrainian nationals on a cash bond of Rs 1 lakh each. The court also discharged them under sections 21 (penalty for unauthorised entry) and 23 (penalty for visa overstay and general contraventions) of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, taking note of the compounding of offences by the Foreigners Regional Registration Office (FRRO). The FRRO had earlier compounded the offences by imposing a fine of Rs 5.5 lakh on each. Ukrainian citizens Petro Hurba, Taras Slyviak and Ivan Sukmanovskiy were arrested from the Lucknow airport on March 13. Three other Ukrainians – Marian Stefankiv, Maksim Honcharuk and Viktor Kaminskyi – were arrested from the Delhi airport the same day. It was alleged that the six were operating as mercenaries. Meanwhile, the court modified the bail condition of US national Matthew Aaron Van Dyke, who was granted default bail on

September 18 on furnishing a personal bond and surety bonds of ₹1 lakh each. Van Dyke's plea to go home to the United States will be heard on Friday. On Wednesday, the court directed the furnishing of only a cash bond of Rs 1 lakh each. The NIA had earlier registered the case against the Ukrainian nationals and Van Dyke under section 18 (punishment for conspiracy) of the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), along with sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The NIA had probed the case as involving alleged UAPA offences for 180 days after obtaining an extension from the court. However, in its first chargesheet filed on September 8, it invoked provisions of the Immigration and Foreigners Act, while stating that the UAPA probe was continuing. The agency had said the investigation into offences under the UAPA was kept pending and it could file a supplementary chargesheet if an offence under the anti-terror law was established. The NIA had also said a substantial part of the further investigation into alleged offences under the UAPA was completed, but more time was required to ascertain the complete facts, particularly in view of the import and recovery of a large quantity of drones and accessories through India.

Illegal mining: SC takes note of killing of forest ranger in Rajasthan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Taking note of a recent incident in which a forest ranger was killed after being allegedly hit by a dumper while he was trying to stop illegal mining in Rajasthan, the Supreme Court on Wednesday said there should be mandatory preventive detention in these cases. The matter was mentioned before a bench of justices Vikram Nath, Augustine George Masih and Sandeep Mehta in a pending suo motu case titled 'In Re: Illegal sand mining in the National Chambal Sanctuary and threat to endangered aquatic wildlife'. The advocate, who mentioned the matter, said another incident has come to light and a forest officer has



been crushed to death by a dumper in Rajasthan. The bench posted the matter for hearing on October 6. "Come prepared with a response," the bench told the counsel appearing for Rajasthan. "There should be mandatory preventive detention in these cases," the top court observed. The incident occurred late on Monday in the Chhoti Sadri forest area when forest ranger Pratap Singh Chundawat and a forest guard reached the spot

following inputs about illegal mining, the officials had said on September 22. According to officials, Singh tried to stop a dumper carrying soil when the driver allegedly hit him and dragged him along with his motorcycle for several metres before fleeing. The injured ranger was taken to a hospital and later referred to the district hospital in Nimbahera, where he died during treatment, officials had said.

Divisional Forest Officer Suresh Chandra Agarwal said the department had received information about illegal mining in the forest area and a team went to the spot to take action. On July 22, the apex court had said preventive detention orders should be passed against those facilitating illegal sand mining activities in and around the National Chambal Sanctuary, as such people were eating into natural resources and deserve no sympathy. The National Chambal Sanctuary, also called the National Chambal Gharial Wildlife Sanctuary, is a 5,400-sq km tri-state protected area. Besides the endangered gharial (long-snouted crocodile), it is home to the red-crowned roof turtle and the endangered Ganges river dolphin.

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BUSINESS11

Finance Minister urges BRICS tax cooperation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Wednesday urged BRICS nations to share their experiences on treaty interpretation and multilateral negotiations in international taxation, saying global transfer pricing disputes “disproportionately” burden developing countries.

India has proposed to set up two new working groups, International Taxation and Transfer Pricing and Revenue Statistics, at a time when international tax rules are being renegotiated, Sitharaman said, addressing the BRICS heads of tax authorities meeting here.

“The rules of international taxation are being renegotiated. There are several multilateral tax issues, including the UN Framework

Convention on International Tax Cooperation, under active negotiation.

The decisions made in these processes over the next few years will shape cross-border taxation for a generation. “BRICS economies, as

source jurisdictions, as large developing economies, as countries that have built significant domestic tax capacity from a low base, have a perspective on those negotiations that is essential to their fairness and their dura-

bility,” Sitharaman said.

Transfer pricing refers to the pricing of goods and services that are exchanged between related companies. International transfer pricing disputes arise mainly because countries seek to ensure that MNCs are subject to tax on an appropriate share of the profits attributable to their respective jurisdictions.

Accordingly, differences in the allocation of taxable income among countries can give rise to disputes between taxpayers and tax authorities, as well as between tax authorities in different jurisdictions.

“Transfer pricing disputes cost developing—country administrations disproportionately. Revenue frameworks that don’t fit our fiscal realities distort how we see and how we see our-

selves,” Sitharaman said, adding that the BRICS working groups will work based on common experience from all the member countries.

She said the proposed working group will have “larger significance” in the context of ongoing renegotiations in the rules of international taxation and fairness in taxation of BRICS economies, which are mainly the source jurisdictions in transfer pricing.

Sitharaman also said the world’s tax administrations are navigating the same transformation — from paper-based, relationship-dependent processes to data-driven, digitally-mediated systems.

Revenue Secretary Arvind Shrivastava said BRICS tax experts have spent two days reviewing the scope of work

of the working group.

The International Taxation and Transfer Pricing Working Group creates a permanent BRICS platform for sharing experience on treaty interpretation, transfer pricing audit, APA (advance pricing agreement) and MAP (Mutual Agreement Procedure) mechanisms, and the multilateral negotiations including the UNFICTC (United Nations Framework Convention on International Tax Cooperation) — where our collective voice is needed and currently insufficient, he said.

The Revenue Statistics Working Group creates a framework for measuring fiscal performance that reflects BRICS realities rather than importing assumptions from frameworks built for very different economies, Shrivastava said.

Gold price drops ₹900 to ₹1.54 lakh/10g

Gold prices fell for the third straight session, declining ₹900 to ₹1.54 lakh per 10 grams in the National capital on Wednesday as a stronger US dollar and weak global trends weighed on investor sentiment.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at ₹1,54,900 per 10 grams on Tuesday. Silver, however, remained unchanged for the second straight session at ₹2.42 lakh per kilogram, inclusive of all taxes, according to local traders. “Gold traded weak on Wednesday as traders booked profits at higher levels,” said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst –Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

The dollar index rose towards 100.85, adding further pressure on bullion, he added. While gold prices have weakened in recent sessions, the precious metal remains significantly more expensive than a year ago, a change that is also altering the way domestic consumers buy it. According to Akshat Garg, Head of Research & Product at Choice Wealth, the 15 per cent fall in Ganesh Chaturthi sales volumes does not mean Indians have lost their affinity for gold; rather, it shows a change in how they buy it. (PNS)

Patient safety top priority, Pfizer says after Karnataka FDA action

Pfizer on Tuesday said patient safety and product quality are its highest priorities, reacting to the Karnataka Food and Drug Administration’s (FDA) action regarding the circulation of counterfeit drugs.

The Karnataka health regulator on Sunday said it has cancelled 16 drug licences of retailers and wholesalers and suspended eight others in connection with the alleged distribution and sale of spurious medicines.

“Patient safety and product quality are of the highest priority for us at Pfizer,” the company said in a statement late on Tuesday evening.

Pfizer claimed that it has been working with authorities for the last one month since the matter was brought to its attention.

“Since then, we have taken several actions to support the investigation, including removing from the market Pfizer batches (where batch numbers were copied by counterfeit) to avoid confusion, supporting to differentiate between original and counterfeit product, and providing technical and other relevant information related to the affected batches,” the company added.

Pfizer stated that it continues to work closely with authorities to resolve the open queries, emphasising that its focus remains on protecting patients, safeguarding public health and maintaining confidence in the healthcare system. (PNS)

Stock markets rebound amid easing crude oil prices

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock index Sensex rebounded by nearly 300 points and the broader Nifty settled near the 24,450 level on Wednesday as below \$100 per barrel crude oil prices and positive India growth forecast by rating agencies boosted buying in metal, financial and FMCG shares.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 299.17 points, or 0.40 per cent, to settle at 74,828.25. During the day, it jumped 444.66 points, or 0.59 per cent, to 74,973.74.

The 50-share NSE Nifty was up 117.80 points, or 0.50 per cent, to end at 23,446.80.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Tata Steel, Bajaj Finance, ITC, UltraTech Cement, Power Grid and

Larsen & Toubro were the major winners.

HCLTech, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, Titan and Mahindra & Mahindra were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, edged up 0.35 per cent to \$99.60 per barrel. “Indian equity benchmarks closed higher on Wednesday, with broad-based buying lifting the market as investors assessed signs of a possible de-escalation in West Asia.

Globally, hopes of easing tensions in West Asia and WTI crude remaining below \$90 a barrel provided additional support to risk sentiment,” Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Global agencies S&P, Fitch, Asian Development Bank (ADB) and OECD on

Wednesday raised India’s FY27 GDP growth projection to around 7 per cent, boosted by robust June quarter economic activity and resilient domestic demand despite conflict in West Asia.

“The combination of a more constructive geopolitical backdrop, softer oil prices and stronger domestic

growth expectations gave investors greater confidence to extend buying beyond the large-cap segment,” Ponmudi added. The BSE SmallCap Select index rallied 0.85 per cent and MidCap Select index was up 0.79 per cent.

Among the BSE sectoral indices, Metal surged 2.37 per cent, Commodities 1.64

RBI absorbs ₹75,026 crore via overnight VRRR auction amid surplus liquidity

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The Reserve Bank on Wednesday absorbed ₹75,026 crore from the banking system through an overnight variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction amid surplus liquidity.

The central bank received bids worth ₹87,993 crore for a notified amount of ₹75,000 crore, but it accepted only ₹75,026 crore, according to the notification.

The bids were accepted at a cut-off and weighted average rate of 5.24 per cent.

The RBI has been conducting various VRRR auctions since last month to absorb excess liquidity from the banking system and align overnight money market rates to the repo rate. Currently, liquidity in the

banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around Rs 4.45 lakh crore as on September 22, as per RBI data.

The central bank also conducted two open market operations (OMO) sales of government securities worth ₹50,000 crore on September 17 and ₹25,000 crore on September 21. Under an OMO sale, banks and other

investors buy government securities from the RBI, thereby draining rupee liquidity from the banking system. The central bank had announced OMO sales totalling ₹1 lakh crore in three tranches to manage the prevailing liquidity conditions. The remaining last tranche of ₹25,000 crore is scheduled for September 28.

The banking system was flushed with liquidity due to heavy mobilisation of FCNR (B) deposits by banks, as the mobilisation brought foreign currency into the system, and subsequent swaps with the RBI provided rupee liquidity to banks.

Besides FCNR(B) inflows, month-end government expenditure, including payments toward salaries and pensions, also added to liquidity in the banking system.

Pre-budget meetings begins from October 12

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The finance ministry will begin a month-long series of pre-budget meetings from October 12 as part of the preparations for Union Budget 2027-28.

“Pre-budget discussions to finalise RE (Revised Estimate) 2026-27 and BE (Budget Estimate) 2027-28 in respect of the Grants/appropriations will commence with effect from 12.10.2026 under the Chairmanship of Secretary (Expenditure),” a notice by the Budget Division of the ministry said. The notice dated September 23, 2026, circulated to all ministries and departments, has a schedule of meetings with the Department of Expenditure. The schedule has been prepared

taking into account various exigencies, and is being circulated well in advance.

Hence, ministries and departments should ensure that the necessary details required should be submitted by October 6, 2026, the notice said.

These meetings will continue till November 13 as per the schedule. The budget for the next financial year is expected to focus on the reform continuation exercise to further accelerate economic growth, along with measures to create jobs.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee fell 12 paise to close at ₹95.74 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday, weighed down by the broad strength of the American currency and a slight recovery in crude oil prices from lower levels.

Forex traders said the dollar strengthened on hawkish comments from US Federal Reserve officials, raising expectations of a rate hike by the US Fed in 2026. However, positive domestic markets supported the rupee at lower levels.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.58 against the US dollar, then gained ground and touched an intraday high of 95.57 against the American currency in intraday trade.

The domestic unit saw an intraday low of 95.76 and ended the trading session on Wednesday at 95.74 (provisional) against the American currency, lower by 12 paise from its previous close. On Tuesday, the rupee appreciated 16 paise to close at 95.62 against the US dollar.

Adani overtakes Ambani as richest Indian

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gautam Adani and family reclaimed the top spot on India’s rich list, overtaking Mukesh Ambani, as the country’s billionaire population hit a record 391, according to the M3M Hurun India Rich List.

Adani’s wealth rose 13 per cent to ₹9.23 lakh crore (\$ 96 billion), while Ambani’s fell 10 per cent to ₹8.63 lakh crore, leaving a gap of ₹59,400 crore between the two. Lakshmi Niwas Mittal and family jumped to third place, with wealth nearly doubling to ₹3.39 lakh crore, boosted by higher European steel prices and trade protection.

Vaccine maker Serum Institute’s Cyrus Poonawalla and family were ranked fourth, followed by HCL’s Roshni Nadar Malhotra, Kumar Mangalam Birla, Sun Pharmaceutical’s Dilip Shanghvi and Wipro’s Azim Premji. Anil Agarwal and family climbed to ninth with ₹2.08 lakh crore, while Samir Mehta and family entered the top 10 at 10th after a 52 per cent increase in wealth following the completion of the JB Chemicals merger. “Charted together over a decade, the ten

richest Indians cross and re-cross one another repeatedly. The most closely fought contest is at the top: Gautam Adani and family overtook Mukesh Ambani and family in 2022, fell behind again in 2023, retook the lead in 2024, lost it in 2025, and have now reclaimed it—five changes of position in five years,” Hurun said. Adani’s line is also the most volatile on the chart, peaking at ₹11.62 lakh crore in 2024, then falling to ₹8.15 lakh crore before recovering to ₹9.23 lakh crore.

Mukesh Ambani’s line rose from ₹2.58 lakh crore in 2017

to ₹10.15 lakh crore in 2024 but has since given up ground in two successive years to ₹8.63 lakh crore.

“The chase pack is where the weaving is densest. All eight of the remaining top ten sat between ₹17,300 crore and ₹2.58 lakh crore in 2017 and are now bunched between ₹1.89 lakh crore and ₹3.39 lakh crore, having traded places many times over. LN Mittal & family began the decade ahead of the group, slipped behind between 2020 and 2022, and have surged clear to third at ₹3.39 lakh crore.

Kia India launches digital finance platform for car buyers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Kia India has launched Kia Quick Finance, a digital financing platform aimed at cutting the time it takes car buyers to secure a loan at its dealerships.

The system is built into Kia’s dealer sales network. Dealership staff can start a customer’s finance application digitally, compare loan offers from participating financiers and send the

considers it appropriate and necessary to recommend continuation of definitive duties...for a period of five years,” the DGTR has said in a notification.

The application for initiation of sunset review investigation was filed by Hindalco Industries, LSBK Aluminium Foils, Raviraj Foils, Shree Venkateshwara Electrocast, Shyam Sel and Power Ltd, and SRF Altech Ltd.

The notification added that dumped imports have impacted the profitability of the domestic industry. “Despite duties in force, there are significant imports, especially from Thailand...Chinese exporters are highly export oriented and are likely to export higher quantities if duties

cease,” it said. In September 2021, the duty was first imposed for five years.

Anti-dumping probes are conducted by countries to determine whether domestic industries have been hurt due to a surge in cheap imports. As a countermeasure, they impose these duties under the mul-

tilateral regime of the Geneva-based World Trade Organisation (WTO). The duty is aimed at ensuring fair trading practices and creating a level playing field for domestic producers vis-a-vis foreign producers and exporters.

All four countries are members of the WTO.

India has already imposed anti-dumping duties on several products to tackle cheap imports from various countries, including China.

India’s exports to China rose 36.66 per cent to \$19.47 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 16 per cent to \$131.63 billion. The trade deficit swelled to an all-time high of \$112.6 billion in 2025-26 from \$99.2 billion in 2024-25.

FROM THE WORLD

USA

Aid for Nepal announced

The US announced \$31 million in funding for Nepal to build bridges in flood-affected areas, address civic needs of affected communities and support the deployment of drones to assist in future disaster recovery efforts.

Under Secretary of State for Political Affairs Allison Hooker made the announcement on Tuesday after meeting Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal in New York on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly Session.

UK

Prince Harry warns against AI

Prince Harry warned Wednesday at the Clinton Global Initiative that artificial intelligence chatbots designed to provide companionship are even more dangerous to young people than social media. "The technology is more persuasive, more intimate, and more powerful," the Duke of Sussex said. "AI is learning how to enter our relationships."

Jaishankar raises Russia oil sanctions concerns with Rubio

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India's concerns over Washington's latest sanctions framework targeting countries that continue to purchase Russian energy emerged as a key issue during External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's meeting with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly on Wednesday.

The contrast between the two sides' public accounts of the meeting was notable. Jaishankar's social media post specifically identified the newly enacted sanctions legislation as one of the subjects discussed, alongside developments in the Gulf and the Ukraine conflict. Rubio, by contrast, made no public mention of the sanctions issue. His post described the meeting as part of efforts to



Union Minister S Jaishankar exchanges a handshake with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio during the UN General Assembly High-Level Week in New York, US

strengthen the US-India strategic partnership and coordinate on regional and multilateral priorities.

The divergence comes days after New Delhi cautioned Washington that applying the new sanctions

mechanism against India could affect bilateral relations. The Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act (SRIA), signed into law by President Donald Trump last week, gives the US administration the power to impose tariffs of up to 100 per cent on countries that are major purchasers of Russian oil and gas.

India has maintained that national and economic interests guide its energy purchases. New Delhi has also stressed the importance of maintaining access to affordable energy for its population of around 1.4 billion people and said it will take steps to safeguard its economic interests.

The sanctions debate has also raised questions about Washington's own energy relationship with Russia. The United States has retained an exemption permitting Russian uranium

imports, even while threatening penalties against other countries that continue buying Russian energy. US reliance on Russian-origin enrichment services remained significant in 2025, as Washington worked to expand alternative domestic capacity. Former US official and South Asia specialist Evan Feigenbaum has also questioned the consistency of Washington's approach.

He has pointed to US consideration of a potential agreement to purchase potash from Belarus, a close Russian ally, while India faces pressure over its Russian energy imports. Trump has presented the proposed Belarus deal as a means of securing lower-cost fertilizer for US farmers.

Meanwhile, energy costs have become another politically sensitive issue in the United States.

Diesel prices have risen sharply, increasing expenses for farmers, trucking companies and other businesses throughout the agricultural supply chain. The administration has consequently been considering measures to limit diesel exports.

India, France and the United Arab Emirates have held a trilateral ministerial meeting here on the margins of the UN General Assembly to discuss the situation in West Asia and review the progress in trilateral cooperation in areas such as space and artificial intelligence. External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, French Foreign Minister Jean-Noel Barrot and UAE Foreign Minister and Deputy Prime Minister Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan led the India-France-UAE Trilateral Ministerial Meeting convened.

Iranian advisers helped Houthis seize Yemen coast: Sources

SAMY MAGDY ■ Cairo

It took Houthi rebels less than 48 hours to seize Yemen's Red Sea coast from pro-Government forces in a resounding blow to US interests and Washington's regional allies.

But the Houthis didn't do it alone. Iranian Revolutionary Guard advisers were in the field helping direct the battle, people familiar with the offensive told The Associated Press, marking Iran's most



direct intervention in favour of its longtime ally since Yemen's civil war erupted in 2014.

The intervention shows how Iran has built the Houthis into a major regional partner able to open a new front in the wider war with the US. The rebels' biggest land grab in years, along with the closure of a key Saudi pipeline, strengthened their ability to choke off Saudi Arabia's oil exports, pushing up global fuel prices and giving Iran greater leverage.

The United States has seemed reluctant to help its ally Saudi Arabia, even as the Houthis have gained momentum in Yemen's revived civil war.

The AP spoke to 10 officials and soldiers to assemble an account of the Houthi offensive. They included a senior Houthi official, two regional officials, a top Yemeni military commander and a member of Yemen's ruling presidential council. They spoke on condition of anonymity to

discuss internal decision-making. The Houthis' swift, 115-kilometre (75-mile) assault exploited divisions among forces allied with Yemen's Saudi-backed, internationally recognised Government. The Houthis penetrated the internal communications of one of the main forces, the National Resistance, allowing them to track its movements and sow confusion.

As pro-Government forces beat a frantic retreat, the leader of the National Resistance fled to Saudi Arabia. The key port city of Mokha was abandoned as residents left in the night, allowing the Houthis to roll in unopposed on Sept. 10. Their seizure of strategic islands nearby further enhanced their ability to attack Saudi oil shipments in the Red Sea.

The Houthis had not conducted a major campaign along the coast since 2017, when Government forces drove them out of the area. Since then, the Houthis have focused on trying to capture the oil-rich province of Marib in central Yemen.

Victims of terrorism by US: Iranian President at UN

FARNOUSH AMIRI ■ United Nations

Iran's president said Wednesday that his people have been "victims of terrorism" by the United States, delivering a rare wartime speech at the UN General Assembly a day after President Donald Trump said he could "annihilate" the Islamic Republic.

In a defiant speech, President Masoud Pezeshkian held up large photos of the late Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and the more than 150 school-children killed on the first days of the war. "We have only defended ourselves.



We are not terrorists," Pezeshkian said at the General Assembly.

"Our innocent people have been the targets of cowardly attacks and aggressions imposed upon our country. And we defended ourselves with utmost

strength. America and Israel attacked us." He added about the United States: "Yes, they did hit us, but we did not bend the knee." Toward the end of his speech, Pezeshkian called out Trump by name. "It must be understood by Mr

Trump and those who seek to bully us that we are ready for dialogue and diplomacy and negotiations without accepting the language of force," he said.

He also said one thing that was measurably false: "We did not hit civilian populations." Arriving in New York under heavy security and scrutiny, Pezeshkian — who, within Iran's political landscape, is considered a moderate politician — addressed world leaders a day after Trump used the same stage to suggest he may "annihilate" the Islamic Republic if a deal isn't reached soon to end the nearly seven-month war. (AP)

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, hitherto known as **INDRA PAL** S/o RAJPAL, R/o Haibatpur, Gautam Buddh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201009, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as **INDRAPAL YADAV**.

I, **Krishna Tripathi**, wife of Yogesh Tripathi, resident of 83, DK-1, New Delhi, have changed my name from 'Krishna Tripathi' to 'Krishna Bhati' vide Affidavit dated 21/09/2026 before Mr. RV Singh, Advocate, Delhi area.

I, have changed my name from "SHAHAJAD SAIFI" to "SHAHJAD". Henceforth, I shall be known and recognized as "SHAHJAD" for all future purposes. **SHAHJAD** S/o **NUR MOHAMMAD** R/o **BAJIGARAN**, **WARD NO-1 DASNA**, **GHAZIABAD** U.P.-201001.

I, **Anirudh S/o Devender** Singh Gahlot R/o H.No-341/A Mitraon Delhi-110043 have changed name of my minor daughter Samridhi Gahlot to Samridhi Gahlot.

I, **Vachau Devi Mother of-** No.16016642F Hav Raj Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill- Rasulpur Ahmed, PO- Nonhara, Teh- Mohammadabad, Dist- Ghazipur, U.P.- 233303, have changed my name from Vachau Devi to Bachiya Singh, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Parkash Kanwar**, W/o- No.8432124N NK/PO Narayan Singh Jagat, R/o- Vill- Kuchetiya, PO- Chhoti Khatu, Teh- Didwana, Dist- Nagaur, Rajasthan- 341302, have changed my name & DOB from Parkash Kanwar (DOB 05.07.1991) to Prakash Kanwar (DOB 01/07/1990), vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Gurdev Kaur**, Mother of No. 4484457W Hav Charanjit Singh, R/o- VPO- Sandhu Kalan, Teh- Tapa, Dist- Barnala, Punjab- 148102, have changed my name from Baldev Kaur to Gurdev Kaur, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Seema Verma**, W/O, Sudhir Kumar, A - 4, Gali Number - 34, Mahendra Park, Adarshnagar Delhi - 110033, have changed my name to Seema (Both are same person)

I, **Sudheer Kumar**, S/O Lekhraj , A - 4 Gali Number - 34, Mahindra Park, Adarsh Nagar Delhi 110033, have changed my name to Sudhir Kumar (Both are same person)

I, **Lalita Singh**, Mother of No.10136359Y Ex-Hav Binod Kumar Singh, R/o- Vill & PO- Kamhariya, Teh- Chandauli, Dist- Chandauli, U.P.- 232106, have changed my name from Lalita Singh to Lalata Devi, vide affidavit dated 22/09/2026 before SDM Delhi Cantt.

I, **Ravina**, W/o No. 10136699F Nk Sushil Kumar, R/o- Vill- Simli Ismailpur, PO- Akhbarpur, Teh-Nangal Chaudhary, Dist- Mahendragarh, Haryana - 123023, have changed my name from Ravina to Ravina Devi, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Punam Kanwar**, D/o- JC-473840W Nb/Sub Rajendra Singh, R/o- Vill- Gothri, Post- Mandupura, Teh- Makrana, Dist- Nagaur, Rajasthan- 341319, have changed my name from Punam Kanwar to Poonam Rathore, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Suman Suwalka**, W/o- No.7783895N Hav (MP) Dinesh Chandra Suhalka, R/o- Vill- Duvava, Post- Songar, Teh & Dist- Chittorgarh, Rajasthan- 312022, have changed my name from Suman Suwalka to Suman Suhalka, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Kanzariya Santoshi Ben**, W/o No.14856900N HAV/MT Kanzaria Dilip Kumar, R/o- Vill- Hapivadi Harshadpur, Teh - Khambhaliya, Dist - Devbhumi Dwarka, Gujarat - 361305 have changed my name from Kanzariya Santoshi Ben to Kanzaria Santoshiben Dilipkumar, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, **Suvidha Ben**, W/o No.14865052F SEP/MT Golakiya Bharatkumar Dayabhai, R/o- Vill- Bhattvadar, PO- Damnagar, Teh- Lathii, Dist- Amareli, Gujarat - 365220 have changed my name from Suvidha Ben to Suvidhaben Bharatkumar Golakiya, vide affidavit dated 23/09/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

Xi leaves for US for summit with Trump

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Wednesday left for Washington to hold a rare second summit with his US counterpart Donald Trump in less than six months to discuss a broad range of bilateral and international issues.

Xi is accompanied by his wife Peng Liyuan, Cai Qi, a member of the Standing Committee of the Political Bureau of the Communist Party of China Central Committee and director of the General Office of the Central Committee, and Foreign Minister Wang Yi, a member of the Political Bureau of the Central Committee, the foreign ministry said.

Trump had invited Xi and Peng to visit the White



House during his visit to China in May this year.

They are expected to arrive at Joint Base Andrews just outside Washington on Wednesday, where Trump planned to accord a rare airport reception by personally receiving them on the tarmac, according to media reports.

The Chinese Foreign

Ministry has described their second meeting within six months as a "milestone of historic significance".

Trade tariffs, technology, AI, military ties, conflicts in the West Asia, the Russia-Ukraine war, the arms race in space and US arms sales to Taiwan were expected to figure in talks between Xi and Trump. (PTI)

Mehul Choksi's lawyer Vijay Aggarwal denied bail in UK



ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Criminal lawyer Vijay Aggarwal, arrested in London last month on charges of sexual assault, was on Wednesday denied bail by a UK court.

Aggarwal, who has represented fugitive businessman Mehul Choksi in fraud and money laundering proceedings, appeared before Justice John Milne at Southwark Crown Court charged with sexual assault for a bail hearing. The judge ruled against it on the grounds that he posed a flight risk and could fail to appear for his trial scheduled for March 2027. His assistant, Manpreet Kaur, charged with two counts of intentionally encouraging or assisting sexual assault, was to appear via videolink but a prison administrative error led to a failure to attend.)

This resulted in the formal arraignment of both accused to be delayed to a later date. At Wednesday's hearing, the Crown Prosecution Service strongly opposed bail being granted to Aggarwal due to the serious nature of the allegations. (PTI)

Trump's Board of Peace proposes \$2.45b blueprint to begin Gaza reconstruction

MATTHEW LEE ■ New York

The US-backed Board of Peace is proposing a six-month, \$2.45 billion plan to begin reconstruction and governance in Gaza as President Donald Trump's ceasefire plan struggles to stay afloat.

At a meeting of the group's board, the governors unveiled a 66-project blueprint to get things started while acknowledging enormous hurdles that must still be overcome.

The projects include ambitious infrastructure,

education and health initiatives that are designed to support Trump's 20-point plan to end the Israel-Hamas war.

"The need is immense," the board said, noting that full reconstruction from the physical damage across Gaza will cost roughly USD 35.2 billion over the medium term and another USD 71.4 billion in the next 10 years. The ceasefire, which took effect on October 10, was meant to clear the way for a broader process to rebuild Gaza under the guidance of the Board of Peace.

The plan included additional Israeli military withdrawals



from Gaza, the disarmament of Hamas, the arrival of an international peacekeeping force and a new apolitical Palestinian Government to administer the territory's day-to-day affairs.

It also envisioned an ambitious program for rebuilding war-ravaged Gaza. But the US-backed plan has largely stalled. While the ceasefire halted the heaviest fighting and humanitarian conditions have improved, the Israeli military has expanded its control of Gaza and now occupies some 60 per cent of the territory. Hamas has not given up its weapons. The international military force and new Government still have not entered Gaza, and reconstruction has not begun.

Superintending Engineer
Bulandshahr Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr

No. 9234 /96M/E-TENDER/BSR CIRCLE/2026-27 Dated 16.09.2026

Short Term E-Procurement Inviting Tenders

On behalf of Government of Uttar Pradesh, Superintending Engineer Bulandshahr Circle, U.P.P.W.D., Bulandshahr invites following percentage rate bid online through http://etender.up.nic.in from the eligible and approved Contractors registered with P.W.D. class as per column no. 10 below Bridge work Category as applied from Date 03-10-2026 10:00 A.M. to 09-10-2026 up to 12:00 Noon as per the prescribed T-2 of Govt. of U.P. The technical bids will be opened online on dated 09-10-2026 at 12:30 P.M. If the office happens to be closed on the date of opening of the bids as specified, the bids will be opened online on the next working day, at the same time any validity of bid will be considered from the original date. The date and time of opening of the financial bid shall be notified on the website.

S. N.	Name of Work	Estimated cost (Rs. In Lakhs)	Bid Security (Rs.)	Time of Completion work including rainy season	Tender document fee including GST (Rs.)	Address of Executive Engineer including P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Address of Superintending Engineer	Address of Chief Engineer	Category
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1.	Reconstruction work of RCC Box Culvert 6x3 in palace of Damage and narrow bridge located at Km 1 of Baral Link Road in District Bulandshahr	94.60	6.73	06 Month	Tender Cost Rs. 300+ 2000+ 18% GST. Rs. 414.0 = 2714.00	Executive Engineer Construction Division-2, P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Superintending Engineer Bulandshahr Circle, P.W.D., Bulandshahr	Chief Engineer, Meerut Zone, P.W.D., Meerut	A, B Bridge Work

1. Time allowed for completion of Whole work is mention in col. No. 5 with including rainy season.

2. The Tender Document fee must be deposited through Internet Banking only.

3. All registered contractors have to upload Turnover certified by C.A. of last 5 years and details of maximum cost of work satisfactorily completed in last 5 years on Chanakya Software before submission of tender.

4. Details of e-tender uploaded on http://etender.up.nic.in shall also be uploaded on UP PWD Chanakya software, before last date & time of submission of bid.

5. Terms & other conditions related to bid are available on http://etender.up.nic.in

6. In PWD technical evaluation of tenders is to be done by Prahar Software URL for Prahar is http://wms.uppwd.gov.in/Prahar/

(Partap Singh) Executive Engineer C.D.-2, P.W.D. Bulandshahr

(Maneesh Verma) Superintending Engineer Bulandshahr Circle, P.W.D. Bulandshahr

UP= 256766 Dt. 22.9.26
गिज्ञापन वेबसाइट www.upgov.nic.in पर उपलब्ध है

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public and all concerned that my client, Ms. Roopa Paul, D/o Late Sh. Darshan Ram, has severed all her personal, social and family relations with her brother, Sh. Deepak Kumar, S/o Late Sh. Darshan Ram, his wife Ms. Komal and their children, all presently residing at F-20-21, Anya Samaj Road, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059. My client maintains no connection or association with them due to their past behavior and conduct with my client. The public, financial institutions, and authorities are informed that my client shall not be held responsible or liable for any debts, acts, omissions, transactions, or legal obligations incurred by them, whether past, present, or future. They are not authorized to use my client's name or credentials, and anyone dealing with them does so strictly at their own risk.

Rahul Kumar (Advocate) 160 Ashoka Enclave Main, Sector-35, Faridabad-121003 (HR) Mobile No. 9717776572

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Systems)

On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office at:- Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonapat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:-

NIT No.	23-RCNK-OPN-TCR-2026
Name of Work and its location	"Replacement of cabin in Railway Truck No. HR69E9122 model TATA 1918C RCNK, Sonipat (As per scope of work)"
Approx Cost of work	Rs 2,95,000.00/- including GST @18% (Rs. Two Lakh Ninety-Five Thousand only)
Earnest Money	Rs. 5900.00/-
Completion period of work	30 days from date of issue of Letter of acceptance
Cost of Tender document (In Rs)	NIL
Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Up to 15:00 hrs on 15.10.2026 Opening of Tender at 15:30 hrs on same day.
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
Tender No. 23-RCNK-OPN-TCR-2026 Dated:22.09.2026	3311/2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE	

16 militants killed in Pakistan's Balochistan

PTI ■ Karachi

Sixteen militants were killed in multiple operations in Pakistan's Balochistan province on Wednesday, state-owned media reported.

The operations were conducted in the Mastung, Turbat and Quetta districts, Radio Pakistan said. Nine militants were killed after they attempted to attack a security post in Mastung's Kanak Valley, it said.

Weapons, ammunition and three motorcycles were recovered from their possession, the state media said, adding that one security personnel was injured in the exchange of fire.

Indian seafarer killed in attack on commercial vessel off Oman coast

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

An Indian national tragically lost his life while 19 others were rescued after the commercial vessel MV Cape Dao came under attack off the eastern coast of Oman while en route to India, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) and the Indian Embassy in Muscat confirmed on Wednesday.

The fatal strike marks a sharp escalation in regional maritime insecurity, triggering swift diplomatic coordination between New Delhi and Muscat alongside a stern call from India for an immediate end to targeted strikes on international shipping lanes.

Following the attack, the Embassy of India in Muscat issued an official statement outlining ongoing safety and relief protocols for the ship's crew: "We are closely monitoring the attack on MV Cape Dao today while transiting toward India, and are in close coordination with Omani authorities regarding the safety of all



crew on board, including 19 Indian nationals. We are deeply saddened by the loss of one Indian national in this attack. Our heartfelt condolences to the bereaved family. The Mission is coordinating with the RPSL [Recruitment and Placement Services Licence] and is in touch with the family of the deceased." Omani

authorities rendered immediate assistance, facilitating the rescue of 19 Indian seafarers from the damaged vessel.

MEA strongly condemns strikes on civilian infrastructure

In an official statement released shortly after the Indian Embassy's confirmation, India's Ministry of External Affairs condemned the assault in clear terms, demanding an immediate return to dialogue and de-escalation in the volatile region.

The MEA stated: "We condemn the attack on the commercial vessel MV Cape Dao earlier today off the east coast of Oman. Of the 20 Indian seafarers on board, 19 have been rescued, while 1 Indian national tragically lost his life. We offer our deepest condolences to the family of the deceased. Our Embassy in Oman is closely monitoring the situation and proactively coordinating with the Omani authorities for early repatriation of the Indian seafarers. We

thank the Omani authorities for their support.

"The continuing incidents of attacks on commercial shipping in the region are deeply worrisome. We reiterate our call for dialogue and diplomacy to de-escalate tensions and enable early return of peace to the region.

The targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers and civilian infrastructure in the region must end, and free and unimpeded navigation and commerce through the international waterways in the region must be restored at the earliest."

The attack on the MV Cape Dao comes amidst growing global concern over the safety of commercial shipping corridors across critical West Asian waterways.

Indian officials are working directly with Omani maritime authorities and recruitment agencies to arrange the prompt repatriation of the surviving 19 Indian crew members and facilitate the return of the deceased sailor's remains.

Mass shooting at South Africa party leaves 11 dead, 3 hurt

GERALD IMRAY ■ Cape Town

Three shooters killed at least 11 people including a woman who was believed to be pregnant in a late-night attack at a house party in South Africa, police said on Wednesday.

Three others were wounded in the mass shooting Tuesday night in KwaMakhutha township around 30 kilometers (19 miles) south of the city of Durban on the east coast.

The people had gathered at the house for a party when the suspects entered the house and opened fire, police said. Ten people, including the pregnant woman, died at the scene and an 11th was declared dead at the hospital.

Authorities did not immediately give out details on the condition of the three people who were wounded.

Police said they were searching for three men and no arrests had been made.

The motive for the shooting was not known, police said, but added that some of the people at the house were known to police as part of investigations into criminal activity. Police said they couldn't give out any more information on those investigations.

"Although the motive of the shooting



cannot be confirmed yet, (a) feud between rival groupings cannot be ruled out," police said.

Thami Ntuli, the premier of KwaZulu-Natal province, told reporters at the scene that the killings were "really disturbing." He said that there were known problems with drug dealing and illegal firearms in the largely impoverished community. (AP)

Pakistan shoots down 8 drones allegedly launched from Afghanistan

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's security forces on Wednesday shot down eight drones allegedly launched from Afghanistan after they entered Pakistani airspace, security sources said, as fresh clashes along the border added to tensions between the two neighbouring countries.

Four drones were brought down near the Torkham border and another four in mountainous areas near Kohat in northwest Pakistan's

Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa province, the sources said. The claims could not be independently

verified.

Some of the drones were described as rudimentary models, with those detected near Kohat neutralised through a "soft-kill" operation, the sources said.

Pakistani authorities alleged that the drones were intended to target public areas and described the incident as further evidence of what they called the Afghan Taliban's support for militants operating against Pakistan.

The drone incident came amid fresh exchanges of fire along the Pakistan-Afghanistan border after Pakistani officials said secu-



rity forces had foiled an infiltration attempt by militants from areas near Afghan border posts in Paktia and Nangarhar provinces.

According to Pakistani officials, Afghan Taliban forces subsequently fired mortars and other heavy weapons at Pakistani border posts,

prompting Pakistani troops to respond with artillery fire targeting Taliban posts, mortar sites and defensive positions.

Afghanistan denied Pakistan's claim, with the Taliban Government rejecting allegations that Afghan Taliban forces had attacked Pakistani positions.

The latest escalation follows Pakistani airstrikes in Afghanistan two days ago, which Islamabad said targeted camps and hideouts of militants belonging to the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP).

Pakistan's Information Ministry said on Monday that

28 militants, including several suicide bombers, were killed in the strikes. Afghan authorities disputed the account, saying at least three civilians were killed and four others wounded in villages in Afghan territory.

The UN mission in Afghanistan confirmed the civilian casualties, while Kabul formally protested the strikes.

The TTP is separate from but allied with the Afghan Taliban, which returned to power in Afghanistan in 2021.

Pakistan has repeatedly accused the Taliban Government in Kabul of sheltering TTP leaders and allow-

ing militants to use Afghan territory to carry out attacks inside Pakistan, while Kabul has consistently denied the allegations.

The latest confrontation is part of a broader deterioration in relations between Islamabad and Kabul, with cross-border violence and accusations of militant activity straining ties.

On the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York, Pakistani Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar expressed concern over what he said was the presence of more than two dozen anti-Pakistani militant groups in Afghanistan. (PTI)

Bangladesh to buy 11 more US Boeing planes



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Bangladesh is set to sign an agreement with Boeing to procure 11 additional aircraft, officials of state-run Biman Bangladesh Airlines said on Wednesday.

The agreement is scheduled to be signed in New York on Thursday, coinciding with Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's visit to the US to attend the annual UN General Assembly session.

The 11 aircraft will be procured in addition to 14 aircraft under an earlier \$3.7 billion agreement signed with Boeing on April 30, taking Biman's planned Boeing acquisitions to 25, the officials said. US Ambassador to Bangladesh Brent T Christensen welcomed Dhaka's decision to procure the additional aircraft, describing them as the "world's best commercial

planes" and the development as "another win-win for the US-Bangladesh relationship".

The models, price, financing terms and delivery schedule for the additional aircraft have not been publicly disclosed. The latest proposal to procure 11 more Boeing aircraft comes amid continued calls from European countries for Bangladesh to ensure a level playing field for Airbus.

However, officials said that Bangladesh has not ruled out procuring Airbus aircraft, and negotiations with the European conglomerate are underway.

The proposed Boeing deal was announced a day after French Ambassador to Bangladesh Jean-Marc Sere-Charlet said Paris was watching "closely" Dhaka's negotiations with Airbus and described the talks as a "test" of Bangladesh's appetite for a long-term partnership with Europe.

Ex-Pak General named chief of Makkah Pact

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

A former Pakistan Army general has been appointed as the first secretary-general of the trilateral Makkah alliance involving Pakistan, Turkiye and Saudi Arabia, the Foreign Office (FO) announced on Wednesday.

The trilateral defence agreement, inked last month, establishes a framework for collective deterrence and stipulates that an armed attack against any one of them would be regarded as an attack against all.

"The Government of Pakistan is pleased to announce the appointment of Lt Gen Nauman Mahmood, Hilal-i-Imtiaz (Military), (retired), as the first secretary general pursuant to the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement," the FO said. It said that the secretary



Nauman Mahmood

general will lead the general secretariat of the alliance being established in Riyadh. Mahmood, who belonged to the Baloch Regiment, previously com-

manded a key Pakistan Army corps in the country's restive northwest and served as president of the National Defence University, according to the military.

His appointment comes amid an ongoing escalation involving Saudi Arabia and Yemen's Houthis, who carried out attacks on Saudi territory in recent days and established control over the strategic Bab el-Mandeb Strait in the Red Sea.

Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkiye signed the agreement on August 7.

Its inaugural meeting was held on August 31 in Istanbul, where officials from all member States met to establish the institutional structure of the alliance. It was decided that the secretary-general would be from Pakistan. (PTI)

Expulsion of top PLA generals eliminated political danger, says Chinese military

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

The expulsion of two top PLA generals has "eliminated a major hidden political danger" for the ruling Communist Party and the military, the Chinese army's mouthpiece said on Wednesday, suggesting that the two had challenged the party's control over the armed forces.

The Chinese Communist Party (CPC) on Monday expelled two top officers of the People's Liberation Army (PLA) — Gen Zhang Youxia and Liu Zhenli — from the party and the military for



serious discipline and law violations. "The serious investigation and punishment of the two eliminated a major hidden political danger for

the party and the military and constitutes a major victory in the military's tough, protracted and overall battle against corruption,"

PLA Daily, the mouthpiece of the Chinese military, said in a front-page editorial on Wednesday, referring to Zhang and Liu.

Their removal would promote the "purity and honour" of the military and allow it to accomplish its missions and tasks, the editorial said.

The PLA has "thoroughly uncovered the lingering poisonous influences and accumulated ills, undergone tempering and forging from the inside out", which has "continuously improved the morale and spirit of the troops", the Hong Kong-

based South China Morning Post quoted the editorial as saying. It said the "international situation, national conditions and party and military conditions are all undergoing complex and profound changes" and therefore "we must unify our thinking and actions with the decisions and arrangements of the party Central Committee and the CMC".

The Central Military Commission (CMC) is the overall high command of the PLA headed by President Xi Jinping. Zhang, 75, served as a member of the Political Bureau of the CPC Central

Committee and vice chairman of the CMC, while 61-year-old Liu served as a CMC member and chief of staff of the CMC's joint staff department. Zhang was also a member of the 24-man Politburo, the top decision-making body of the CPC.

They are decorated war heroes and the only CMC members with combat experience. Both took part in PLA campaigns against Vietnam in the late 1970s. The sacking of Zhang, the highest-ranking military official, in particular, has sent shockwaves through the Chinese military establishment. (PTI)

Ethiopian Airlines cancels flights as soldiers take over airport

SAMUEL GETACHEW ■ Addis Ababa

Regional forces in Tigray in northern Ethiopia took control of the airport on Wednesday morning, prompting the state-owned carrier to cancel flights to the troubled region.

OEthiopian Airlines said it suspended flights to Tigray's capital Mekelle and the cities of Axum and Shire "due to the current situation," without providing further details.

A taxi driver told The Associated Press that the airport, which is usually controlled by federal forces, was occupied by soldiers from the Tigray People's Liberation Front carrying light arms. The driver, who requested anonymity for fear of retaliation, said a commander ordered him to leave the airport, saying no flights would be landing. The takeover appeared to be peaceful, with no gunfire



heard in or around the airport. The Tigray People's Liberation Front did not immediately issue a statement. No other airlines fly to the region, although it is reachable by chartered flight.

The cancellations came three days after seven opposition groups, including the Tigray People's Liberation Front, formed an alliance aimed at removing Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed and his Government.

Abiy's Prosperity Party retained power in a June general election that was boycotted by the main opposition groups. The Tigray People's Liberation Front fought federal forces during a deadly conflict in northern Ethiopia that ended with the signing of a peace agreement in November 2022. The opposition groups announced the formation of a coalition they called the Ethiopian Peoples' Forces Alliance for Survival on Sunday. (AP)

Serbian journalists face rising threats before key election: Watchdog

JOVANA GEC ■ Belgrade

An international media watchdog has warned that journalists in Serbia are increasingly under threat of violence and hostility ahead of a high-stakes early parliamentary election next month that will test populist President Aleksandar Vucic's rule.

The Committee to Protect Journalists urged Vucic's Government this week to ensure that journalists(CPJ) can follow the Oct. 25 ballot "safely and without fear."

"Journalists covering the polls are at serious risk of threats, violence and hostility of the sort that has become increasingly common" during Vucic's term, CPJ said in a statement released on Tuesday. The group called on



"Serbia's European partners to monitor the situation closely, encourage Belgrade to guarantee the rule of law is respected and speak out to challenge violations of press freedom."

The Serbian Government did not immediately respond to an Associated Press request for a comment. In the past, Serbia's Ministry of Information has told

the AP it condemned any attacks on journalists and urged a quick state reaction.

An international mission in March documented escalating police violence, smear campaigns fueled by public officials, persistent impunity, legal and digital threats and the ruling party's efforts to tighten its grip over the media, CPJ said.

Serbia is formally seeking membership in the European Union, but the effort has stalled under Vucic, who has faced accusations of clamping down on democratic freedoms, including the media.

Since coming to power in 2012, the ruling populist party has gradually established control over mainstream media while often describing embattled critical outlets as enemies of the State. (AP)

HDFC Mutual Fund launches Indian sign language platform for financial literacy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

HDFC Mutual Fund has launched a dedicated digital platform built entirely in Indian Sign Language (ISL) under its financial literacy initiative, Bharosa, aimed at the Deaf and Hard of Hearing (DHH) community.

The platform was launched on the International Day of Sign Languages and is designed to provide accessible, sign language-based investor education and awareness. With the initiative, HDFC Mutual Fund becomes the first Indian Asset Management Company (AMC) to launch a platform of this kind.

Launched in August 2025, Bharosa has so far engaged around 6,000 individuals from the DHH community through ISL-based investor awareness sessions. The platform allows users to select financial goals, such as retirement or a child's education, and access curated ISL videos related to those goals.

Users can also schedule one-on-one sessions with a DHH coach, who can guide them through their financial journey in Indian Sign Language. Over the past year, HDFC Mutual Fund has engaged with members of the DHH community to understand how they navigate financial decisions.



According to the company, these interactions highlighted a recurring concern — the fear of being misled, stemming not from a lack of ambition but from limited access to financial information in a language people could fully understand.

This insight led to the platform being named 'Bharosa', meaning trust.

Commenting on the initiative, Navneet Munot, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer, HDFC Asset Management Company Limited, said, "Over the years financial inclusion has been measured by access to financial products and services. However, access alone is not enough.

"People also need information in a form they can follow before they can weigh their choices with any confidence. Through our engagement

with the Deaf and hard of hearing community, we learnt how rarely that information is offered in a language they use. Bharosa, our financial literacy platform built entirely in Indian Sign Language, is a step in that direction. It offers videos organised around the goals people save for and one-on-one sessions with coaches from within the community, so that more people can take well-informed financial decisions."

To mark the launch, HDFC Mutual Fund has also released a digital film featuring a young expecting couple from the Deaf and Hard of Hearing community as they imagine the future they want to build for their child.

The film explores the uncertainty that can arise around financial decisions and shows how greater clarity about available

options can help turn that uncertainty into confidence at important moments. It features actors from the Deaf and Hard of Hearing community, with the company highlighting the focus on authenticity and representation.

At the core of Bharosa is the belief that everyone should have access to financial education in a language they understand. Through Indian Sign Language and a dedicated digital platform, HDFC Mutual Fund aims to contribute to greater accessibility, inclusion and financial empowerment.

Watch the film: <https://youtu.be/u4GPG2hFSn0?si=lp9e06g6fZ5ykmyl>
Bharosa platform: <https://www.hdfcfund.com/bharosa>

Investor Education and Awareness Initiative

HDFC Mutual Fund has also advised investors to visit its investor education resources to understand the process for completing the one-time Know Your Customer (KYC) requirement for investing in mutual funds.

Investors should deal only with registered mutual funds, whose details can be verified on the SEBI website. For queries, complaints and grievance redressal, investors can approach the respective AMCs and/or Investor Relations Officers.

Nehru Planetarium hosts experimental activity to mark Equinox Day



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Nehru Planetarium on Wednesday organised an event to mark the Equinox Day, aiming to encourage curiosity, observation and scientific engagement among young learners, a senior official said.

Around 250 students attended talks, and 50 high school and college students took part in an experimental activity at the planetarium in the Teen Murti Bhawan complex, the Prime Ministers' Museum and Library (PMML) said.

These experiments drew inspiration from the historic method associated

with Greek astronomer Eratosthenes, who used shadow observations to estimate the size of the Earth, it said in a statement.

The Nehru Planetarium organised the event as part of an Equinox Day activity. An equinox is an astronomical phenomenon when spans of day and night are equal.

The officials said schools, colleges and scientific institutions participated in activities in Jammu and Kashmir, Kurukshetra, Guwahati, Surat, Bhopal, Hyderabad and Kozhikode.

"This initiative saw school and college students from across India participate in a collaborative scientific activity that

explored the Earth-Sun system through simple observations of the Sun and shadows.

Participants used a vertical stick/pole, measuring scale and clock to observe and record shadows as part of the experiment," the statement said.

By comparing data from two different places, the circumference of Earth and its rotational speed were calculated.

The results were close to the correct value, the PMML said. With the theme "One Sun. Many Shadows. One Earth," the initiative aimed to encourage curiosity, observation and scientific engagement among young learners, it said.

NLC India raises ₹500 crore via issuance of commercial papers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned NLC India Ltd on Wednesday said it raised ₹500 crore by issuing commercial papers. Commercial papers are short-term, unsecured debt obligations issued by institutions and corporations as an alternative to more expensive funding methods.

The issuance comes as NLC India plans to invest ₹1.25 lakh crore by 2030 to expand its capacity. In a filing to BSE, the company said that 10,000 commercial papers of a "face value of ₹500,000 each, aggregating to ₹500 crore have been issued and allotted" on September 22.

NLC India Limited (NLCIL), a Navratna public-sector enterprise under the coal ministry, has an installed power-generation capacity of 8,405 MW and mining capacity of 59.1 million tonnes per annum (MTPA).



To support India's growing electricity needs sustainably, the company is expanding its mining operations through responsible practices while modernising its power-generation portfolio.

NLCIL plans to raise its total mining capacity to 104.35 MTPA by 2030 and further to 115.85 MTPA by 2047, helping reduce the country's dependence on imported coal. NLCIL is also accelerating

its clean-energy transition through its dedicated green subsidiary NLC India Renewables Limited (NIRL). The company aims to expand its operational renewable-energy capacity from 1.8 GW currently to more than 10 GW by 2030, and to 32.7 GW by 2047.

This expansion is expected to raise the share of clean energy to 50 per cent of NLCIL's overall generation mix well ahead of schedule.

RITES, NHIDCL collaborate to boost highway, other infra projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

RITES Limited on Wednesday said it has signed an agreement with National Highways and Infrastructure Development Corporation Limited (NHIDCL) to provide specialised consultancy and technical support for planning, development, and construction of highway projects across the north-east.

Under the agreement, RITES said in a statement that it will provide a broad spectrum of consultancy ser-

vices, including preparation of detailed project reports (DPRs) for highways and tunnels, external technical audits and third-party quality assurance, along with Authority Engineering services for highway, tunnel, and slope stability projects.

The memorandum of understanding (MoU) establishes a framework to enhance project planning, engineering excellence, construction quality, and safety standards across NHIDCL's infrastructure portfolio, it added.



ED raids entities linked to McNally Bharat IBC case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Wednesday conducted searches in three states as part of a FEMA investigation against a Kolkata-based engineering company that recently underwent insolvency, officials said.

They said about 16-17 premises in Kolkata, Delhi and Bengaluru linked to McNally Bharat Engineering Company Limited (MBECL) and persons and entities connected with its acquisition are being covered.

The searches were initiated under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), they said.

The company recently underwent the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) through the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), and the BTL



EPC company's plan was approved.

The ED could not immediately obtain comments from the entities on whom the searches were conducted.

Officials said the ED is investigating suspected FEMA contraventions and the source and movement of funds used in acquiring

control of MBECL.

The agency is also examining whether the insolvency resolution process was used to enable persons "potentially ineligible" under Section 29A of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), 2016, to regain indirect control of the company, they said.

Subhash Chandra moves NCLAT, challenges NCLT 5-member bench order against alienation of assets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Subhash Chandra has moved the appellate tribunal, NCLAT, against the order of a five-member bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), which restrained him from alienating his assets during the pendency of the matter.

Chandra has challenged an order passed by a five-member NCLT bench, formed to decide his personal insolvency, on September 1, which stayed the order passed by the third tie-breaker judge, who voted for ₹6.5 crore repayment against total liabilities of around ₹22,000 crore.

The appeal came up for

hearing before a three-member bench, which asked his counsel to serve the copies to creditors and implead them as parties.

The bench, which includes NCLAT officiating Chairperson Justice Yogesh Khanna, has directed that the matter be listed for the next hearing on September 29.

During the proceedings, counsel representing the creditors told the NCLAT that advance copies of the appeal have not been served on them or they have not been made parties despite having participated in the proceedings before the NCLT.

In his petition, Subhash Chandra has questioned the scope of the order passed by the five-member NCLT bench.

The five-member bench "directed issuance of notices and filing of fresh replies in all pending applications, without defining the scope of the further reference, and imposed a restraint upon the Appellant from alienating "any assets whatsoever either directly or indirectly," the petition said.

Chandra contended that the NCLT order "travels beyond the limited statutory jurisdiction contemplated".

This also "effectively converts a statutory reference for determination of specified points of difference into a de

novo (afresh) rehearing of the entire proceedings," Chandra contended in his petition. Section 419(5) of the



Companies Act lays down the procedure for resolving a split verdict by referring the points of difference to additional members of the tribunal for a majority decision.

Chandra is questioning the formation of the five-member bench by the NCLT.

Earlier, a two-member NCLT bench delivered a split verdict on Chandra's personal insolvency resolution process.

While Member (Judicial) Ashok Kumar Bhardwaj approved ₹6.5 crore repayment plan submitted by Chandra and held that he was eligible to seek relief under the insolvency framework for personal guarantors, Member (Technical) Reeta Kohli disagreed and rejected the proposal,

leading to a reference under Section 419(5) of the Companies Act, 2013.

The matter was subsequently placed before Nilesch Sharma, Member (Judicial), as the third member to decide the points of difference.

Sharma concurred with Bhardwaj on the key issues and upheld Chandra's repayment plan, under which claims of around ₹22,006 crore arising from personal guarantees were proposed to be settled for about ₹6.5 crore.

However, the operation of Sharma's order was later stayed by a five-member NCLT bench, which also restrained Chandra from alienating his assets pending further proceedings.

SEBI considering margin rationalisation for longer-tenure derivatives: Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Markets regulator SEBI is considering rationalising margin requirements for longer-tenure derivative products to encourage healthier, long-term participation in the futures and options (F&O) segment, chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey said on Wednesday. "SEBI is open to reviewing and potentially lowering margin requirements for longer-tenure derivative products to encourage healthier, long-term participation in the Futures & Options (F&O) market," Pandey said on the sidelines of the 13th SBI Banking & Economics Conclave here.

Further, Pandey indicated that the regulator is examining structural measures, including possible adjustments in margins for longer-tenure contracts.

He said the regulator's approach is aimed at ensuring that markets become easier to access while preserving investor protection and trust.

"Ease of doing business and investor protection are not competing objectives," Pandey later said addressing the Conclave.

"Optimum regulation can reduce unnecessary friction. Our objective is therefore to make markets easier to access, while preserving the trust on which those markets are built," he said.

The comments come at a time when regulators have been focusing on the risks faced by retail investors in the equity derivatives segment, where high-frequency trading and leveraged positions can result in substantial losses.

The SEBI chief said India's financial markets have grown substantially, but the next phase should not be measured only by their size.

"We also need to ask: Are our markets becoming deeper and more liquid? Are we creating adequate pools of long-term capital?" he said, while emphasising the need for informed participation as new investors enter markets and new products become available to them.



"The broader principle is straightforward. Ease of doing business and investor protection are not competing objectives," Pandey said.

The SEBI chairman also said that India's growing economy requires different kinds of capital, available for different purposes and

periods, and that banks and capital markets should be viewed as complementary parts of the same financing ecosystem.

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
MARINE DEPARTMENT
No. MD/ACCT/SWKR-09/2025/1152 Date: 14.09.2026
E-TENDER CALL NOTICE (E-TCN)
Name of the Work : Hiring of 01 (one) no. 70Tonn Bollard Pull ASTDS Tug for Handling Fully Loaded Cape Vessel and SPN Operation for a period of 07 (seven) years at Paradip Port Authority.
Estimated cost put to tender: Total estimated cost including Hire Charges & Fuel Rs.140,00,49,552/- excluding GST.
Estimated cost put to Tender towards Hire Charges only Rs. 88,53,40,794/- excluding GST.
Last date & time of submission of tender through on-line bidding is 17:00 Hours on 22.10.2026.
Date & time for opening of Technical Bid is 11:30 hours on dt. 23.10.2026.
For further details, please log on to the Website: <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocureapp>.
Sd/-
PPA/PR/28/2026-2027 Deputy Conservator
22.09.2026 Paradip Port Authority

GURU NANAK DEV UNIVERSITY, AMRITSAR
SHORT TERM E-TENDER NOTICE
Short Term E-Tenders are invited for the purchase of Fast Braiding Machine, Computerised Embroidery Machine Multicolor Single Head for T-shirts, Computerised Embroidery Machine Multicolor Single Head for Ladies' Suits, Honeycomb Tabletop + Passive Vibrational Isolation, Single Photon Detection Module, 532 nm DPSS Laser System, UV-vis-Spectrophotometer, Printing of Certificate, -86 Deep Freezer, Lock-in-Amplifier and All-in-One Desktop, Printer, Photocopier & ACs be submitted online latest by 8/10/2026 upto 4:00 p.m. Detailed information can be obtained from website www.eproc.punjab.gov.in. Any corrigendum/Addendum related to these e-tender will be uploaded, if required, on Punjab Govt. website: eproc.punjab.gov.in
2426/12/2026-27/115499 Dated CHD :- 23/09/2026
Director of Research

"With the adrenaline on track and everything, I think I should be OK," he added. (PTI)

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20 Argue irrationally, having a screwy
point (5)
21 Timely sound, maybe followed by a
squeak (3)
22 Dashed halfway back when dejected (3)
23 Entertain a bird at the West End (6)
25 Combination container? (3)
28 Fat for which wild bees have a love (5)
30 Though having the power, gets nothing
right on test (5)
31 Devon runner known to have a nice
mouth (5)
32 She could be a nit (4)
33 Contrapuntal piece that'll give you a
kick (4)

With his medal assured but a place in the final at stake, Jay mounted a fightback. He responded by taking the fourth game 4-1 and followed it up by edging fifth game 6-4 to reduce deficit and keep his hopes alive.

A photograph of three Indian athletes standing side-by-side against a green background, each holding a bronze medal. From left to right: a man in a white and blue jacket, a man in a blue and white jacket with 'PSW' and 'INDIA' logos, and a man in a blue and white jacket with 'INDIA' and 'Olympic' logos. All three are smiling and holding their medals prominently.

Raiza and Parinaaz then carried India's individual hopes into eight-shooter final. (PTI)

New Zealand pick 7 pacers for T20I series versus India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Wellington

New Zealand picked seven front-line pace bowlers, including a fit-again Adam Milne for their upcoming five-match T20 International series against reigning World Champions India starting October 22 in Christchurch. White-ball captain Mitchell Santner will lead an expanded 16-man T20I squad for the action-packed five-game series spread across 11 days in four cities.

According to the media release issued by the NZC, 13 players from the squad that finished runner-up to India in this year's ICC Men's T20 World Cup have been named for the home series, including spin all-rounder Michael Bracewell and paceman Milne, who were sidelined from the tournament with respective injuries.

The 34-year-old Milne, who has accumulated 243 T20 caps (56 of those international),



last played for the Black Caps against Zimbabwe over a year ago, and bolsters a line-up of seasoned T20I pace bowlers, including Lockie Ferguson, Matt Henry, Kyle Jamieson, and Jacob Duffy, as well as young guns Zak Foulkes and Nathan Smith.

Batting all-rounder Rachin Ravindra, who dislocated his right shoulder during a promotional shoot last week, has been ruled

out of the T20I series. Ravindra's rehabilitation is expected to take around six weeks, with an aim to be available for the ODI series against India starting at Eden Park in Auckland on November 4.

Hard-hitting openers Tim Seifert and Finn Allen will be reunited at the top of the order for the first time since their impressive T20 World Cup campaign, which showcased one of the greatest T20I chases in New Zealand's history.

Gambhir hints at giving white-ball break to batters

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Some of India's top batters could be given a break from white-ball cricket to focus on Test preparations during the upcoming multi-format tour of New Zealand, indicated head coach Gautam Gambhir as he highlighted the challenge of switching from 50-over to five-day cricket in a short span of time.

Gambhir did not explicitly mention New Zealand but the schedule of the lengthy tour is such that India will be lining up for the first Test in Wellington from November 19, which is just three days after the fifth and final ODI against the Black Caps in Tauranga. The marathon tour will feature 12 games across formats. "Often for Test match prepara-

tion, you will have to give your batters a break as well from white-ball to move into Test cricket, because coming from T20 to one-day cricket is easy," Gambhir said.

With only two days of training before the two-Test series, some of the top ODI players like skipper Shubman Gill, wicketkeeper-batter KL Rahul, opener Yashasvi Jaiswal, pacers Bumrah, Siraj, Ravindra Jadeja and Nitish Reddy might skip few ODIs to get ready for WTC.

Gambhir also felt that going forward, there would be very few all-format players left in the game despite the coaches and selectors' desire to have such talent.

"Look, ideally for any coach it is very important that as many players play all three formats, the better it is, because continuity in international cricket is very important," he said.

Jacks, Brook power England to 89-run win over Sri Lanka



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Chester-Le-Street

England extended its white-ball dominance over Sri Lanka by winning the first one-day international by 89 runs on the back of a 67 by captain Harry Brook and a five-wicket haul by part-time spinner Will Jacks. It comes after England won the T20 series between the countries 3-0 last week.

Jacks (5-22) had also contributed with the bat by providing crucial late-innings runs for England with 46 not out before the hosts were restricted to 265. Sri Lanka never threatened on a slow, low pitch and was all out for

176. Brook hit England's only half-century but contributions also came from opener Ben Duckett (32), Joe Root (44) and Jos Buttler (31).

For the visitors, debutant legspinner Sachindu Colombage (3-44) claimed the wickets of Root and Buttler in an impressive first international cricket match. Colombage, a 28-year-old spinner with an unusual action and plenty of drift in his deliveries, bowled Root - who became the eighth batter to pass 23,000 runs in international cricket - for a notable first wicket in internationals and later got rid of another dangerman by trapping Buttler lbw.

Manu breaks down recalling Jaspal Rana after medal miss

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

She held steady after missing out on a medal but Manu Bhaker lost grip on her emotions the moment Jaspal Rana's name cropped up as she recollected the career and life advices from the legend who died of cardiac issues a few months ago.

Bhaker ended fifth in the women's 10m air pistol competition in the Asian Games here on Wednesday. It was the culmination of an emotionally turbulent past few months in which she mourned the demise of Rana, who was a mere 49 at the time of his shocking death.

Asked about pistol legend after missing the podium on Wednesday, Bhaker broke down before speaking about the lessons he had left her with. The Asian Games is the first

multi-sport event she is competing in since Rana's death in June. The mere mention of his name brought back memories of a coach who was a major influence on her career since her formative days.

"If I remember all those years...it's not that you remember once or twice, it stays with you. When a person has been a big part of your life, it stays," said the visibly overwhelmed Bhaker as she remembered the man, who guided her to two bronze medals at the 2024 Paris Olympics.

Rana was himself a bonafide Asian Games legend having won eight medals, four of them gold, across three different editions. His three gold medals in the 2006 Doha Asiad are part of a glorious legacy as he took position at the range despite high fever. (PTI)



Commonwealth Chess Association partners with Chessveda to expand digital chess

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Samarkand

The Commonwealth Chess Association (CCA) has partnered with digital chess platform Chessveda to promote and expand online chess activities across Commonwealth nations.

The agreement was signed here on the sidelines of the 46th Chess Olympiad by CCA chairman Bharat Singh Chauhan and Chessveda chairman Nandan Jha. The signing ceremony was attended by presidents of chess federations from Commonwealth countries, along with Grandmasters, International Masters and other members of the chess



community.

"We are delighted to formalise this partnership with Chessveda and welcome them as an official partner for online chess. Digital platforms are opening new avenues for participation in chess, and this collaboration will enable us to provide more opportunities for players and chess communities across Commonwealth nations to participate and compete," Chauhan said in a release.

"The Commonwealth Chess Association is committed to promoting chess among all its member federations and to creating wider opportunities for players of different ages and levels. Our association with

Chessveda will help us explore new formats and initiatives while complementing our existing over the board chess activities," he added.

Jha said Chessveda aimed to organise online Chess Olympiads and other major championships while providing grassroots players opportunities to compete on global platforms.

Chessveda's platform offers online chess playing, learning and training, tournaments, coaching, chess communities and chess-related content.

The CCA and Chessveda will explore online and hybrid tournaments, championships and other initiatives aimed at expanding participation in chess across Commonwealth nations.

Kabaddi: Indian women beat Iran, men thrash Bangladesh in Asiad



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya

India continued their dominant run in kabaddi at the Asian Games with both men's and women's team registering comprehensive victories over Bangladesh and Iran respectively in their group-stage fixtures here on Wednesday.

While the women's team comfortably beat 2018 gold medallist Iran 37-23 in their second group league match, the men's side saw off Bangladesh 48-25 in their third Group A match here.

"We strategised a lot against Iran, but on the court it was very intense and tough. This is the first time we have won by more than 10 points.

Before that, it was always a close match," women's coach Neeta Dadwe said.

Dadwe said, "No one in the world. India are Number 1. It is our game. It started in India and we practise it a lot. We have a lot of good players and coaches.

"We work on our technique, speed and strength. We have confidence that we are the best." Dadwe said, "Almost all the players are top-notch, but Pooja and Nikita are the stars of the Indian team." Indian women were 19-15 ahead at the half way mark and also extended their domination further in the second half to completely out-class their opponent.

No blue jeans, no camouflage: Asian Games shooting range lays down strict dress code

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

At the Asian Games shooting range, it is not just the athletes who have to keep an eye on the rules. The photographers and TV cameramen covering the competition have a dress code to follow, too - and at the Aichi Prefectural General Shooting Gallery, there is little chance of anyone missing the message.

The dress code has long been part of the International Shooting Sport Federation (ISSF) rule book, but it is not something that is usually spelt out in such stark terms at international competitions or plastered across soft boards around a venue.

The Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games Organising Committee (AINAGOC), however, has made sure there is no ambiguity for those accredited photographers and TV cameramen who have access to the field of play. The message is simple: they are working in the public eye and



are expected to maintain a respectable, professional standard of appearance.

At the picturesque shooting gallery in the hills, around 70-75 km from central Nagoya, signs carrying the instruction are hard to miss. "All media covering shooting events must follow dress code," one poster declares.

There is, however, a small case of overenthusiasm in the wording. The rule is primarily aimed at photographers and TV cameramen working on the

field of play, but the signage broadly refers to "all media".

That distinction became apparent when a video journalist was recently asked to change from blue jeans into black jeans, which are considered more formal under the dress code.

There was just one problem: the shooting venue is deep in the hills, and getting back to Nagoya, changing and returning would have meant a journey of roughly four hours - effectively ending the journalist's working day before the competition did.

The matter was subsequently clarified: the restriction on blue jeans applies to photographers and TV cameramen, not journalists.

The poster itself leaves little room for interpretation. It lists the prohibited clothing as "Blue jeans (black jeans are allowed), camouflage clothing, very short shorts," followed by the reminder: "Please follow the ISSF dress code at all times."

Deepika's record strikes hand India 20-1 win over Thailand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

In-form drag-flicker Deepika Sehrawat continued her impressive run, scoring a record nine goals in a single match as India thrashed Thailand 20-1 to register their third consecutive victory in Pool B of the women's hockey competition at the Asian Games here on Wednesday.

Deepika (2nd, 8th, 9th, 24th, 33rd, 36th, 39th, 51st and 57th minutes) was unstoppable from penalty corners, converting all her nine attempts to script the record haul, while Navneet Kaur (4th, 29th, 35th and 51st) also ran riot in the one-sided contest.

Rutuja Dadaso Pisal (10th, 11th and 47th) completed a hat-trick, while Neha Goyal (19th), Lalremsiami (26th), Sakshi Rana (29th) and skipper Salima Tete (45th) joined the scoring as India piled on the goals.

Thailand's consolation goal was scored from a penalty



corner variation by Supansa Samanso (57th). India will next play hosts Japan on Friday.

India are leading Pool B standings with three wins from as many matches ahead of Japan. The top teams from each pool will qualify for the semifinals of the 12-team competition.